



America's Immigration Mess:

An Illustrated Guide

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Abstract

Immigration was a flashpoint in American politics long before President Biden's election—but it became a major political fiasco with the Biden Administration's mismanagement of illegal immigration. Immigration ended up being one of the top issues in the 2024 election, and is widely recognized as one of the key factors contributing to the re-election of President Trump. America is poised for a very different set of immigration policies today. But wherever America aims to head with immigration policy, it is essential to guide that policy by accurate information. This illustrated guide is intended to offer a summary snapshot of America's immigration situation today, and some of the dilemmas attending it. In this illustrated guide we collect what we take to be the most accurate data and information on a number of hotly debated questions: trends in total and illegal immigration; the Biden era migration surge and its components; immigrants' contributions to the national economy, dependence of US social welfare benefits, and impact on the budget deficit and national debt.

Introduction

Immigration was a flashpoint in American politics long before President Biden's election—but it became a major political fiasco with the Biden Administration's mismanagement of illegal immigration. The Southern Border Crisis of 2021-24 occasioned an influx to the USA of many millions of unauthorized immigrants via Mexico—a surge encouraged by the perception that Washington was taking a new and much more accommodating posture toward unapproved border crossings. The irregular entrants posed well publicized problems to many receiving communities in the USA, and the relaxed Biden Administration attitude toward illegal immigration ultimately proved to be tremendously unpopular. Immigration ended up being one of the top issues in the 2024 election, and is widely recognized as one of the key factors contributing to the re-election of President Trump.

America is poised for a very different set of immigration policies today. But wherever America aims to head with immigration policy, it is essential to guide that policy by accurate information. This illustrated guide is intended to offer a summary snapshot of America's immigration situation today, and some of the dilemmas attending it.

In this illustrated guide we collect what we take to be the most accurate data and information on a number of hotly debated questions: trends in total and illegal immigration; the Biden era migration surge and its components; immigrants' contributions to the national economy, dependence of US social welfare benefits, and impact on the budget deficit and national debt.

We provide our own estimates on some of these questions. But we also include work that we regard as reliable from other researchers steeped in some of these matters. These researchers come from a wide range of organizations, and sometimes hold strong views on immigration policy questions. Some of the researchers whose work we include might disagree with one another—perhaps even strongly. From our perspective that is immaterial to our selections here. In fact we find it reassuring to find valuable empirical work on immigration emanating from a large number of research teams with divergent perspectives. In the following guide we include facts and figures from the following sources, in addition to our own:

- *Brookings Institution*
- *Cato Institute*
- *Center for Immigration Studies*
- *Congressional Budget Office*
- *Danish Finance Ministry*
- *French Institute for Demographic Studies*
- *Gallup*
- *Manhattan Institute*
- *Migration Policy Institute*
- *National Institute on Drug Abuse*
- *Pew Research Center*
- *United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees*
- *Washington Office on Latin America*

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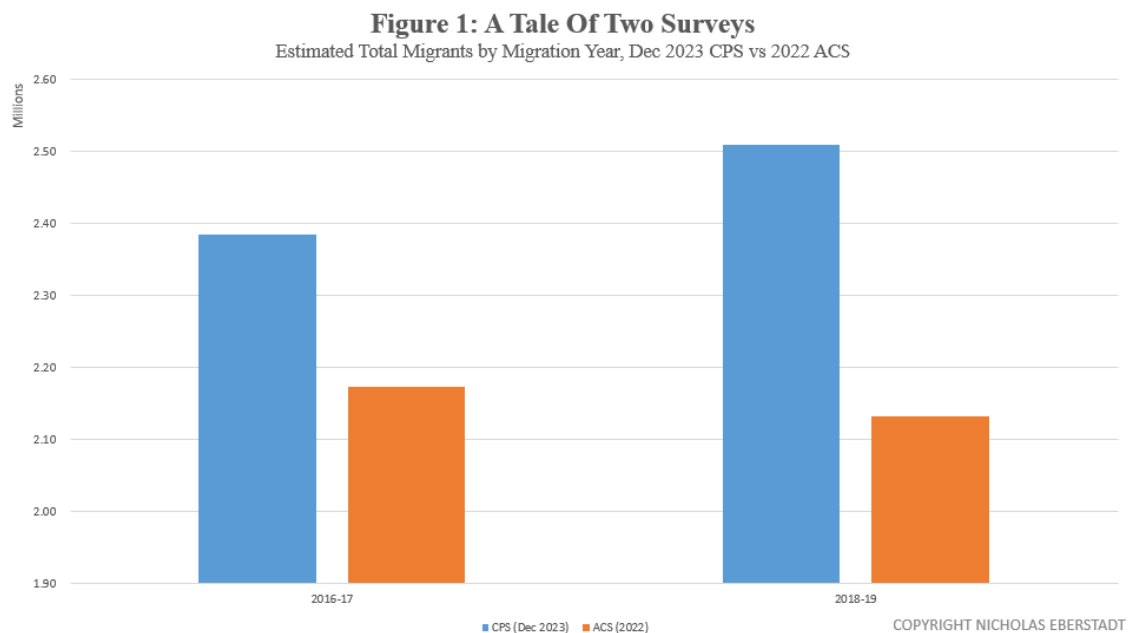
- 1) Immigration: making sense of our least reliable demographic statistics
- 2) Without immigration, US labor force would be shrinking now
- 3) Native-born labor can't fill the US economy's demand for workers
- 4) Underestimated: economic and social costs of immigration/illegal immigration
- 5) Southern Border Crisis migrants: less educated/skilled than other immigrants
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1) Immigration: Making Sense of Our Least Reliable Demographic Statistics

Migration stocks and flows turn out to be unusually difficult to compile in an accurate and timely manner. This is true not just for the United States, but for practically all highly developed Western countries—indeed for practically any modern society with any appreciable volume of border-crossing activity.

Whereas vital registration systems focus on complete and continuous enumeration of births and deaths, migration numbers tend to be calculated by other means. Border authorities and customs officials tabulate entries and departures by foreign nationals—but typically one or both of these quantities is measured inaccurately. Net migration flows can be measured indirectly—as a residual, the difference between total population change and net natural increase (i.e. births minus deaths)—but this ‘rear view’ method is often subject to important revisions in countries where migration accounts for a consequential portion of total annual population change. Official population censuses in principle allow for an accurate reckoning of total foreign-born population over time—but in the US, as in most countries, that national count only takes place every ten years. In the interim between such assessments of total “stock”, annual measures of “flow” tend to be problematic.

Measurement of illegal or unauthorized immigration is all the more difficult for obvious reasons. And a sudden surge of illegal immigration is intrinsically even more challenging to track with real-time accuracy. Yet that is precisely the situation American statistical authorities faced in estimating stocks and flows on legal and illegal immigration into the US during the Biden years.



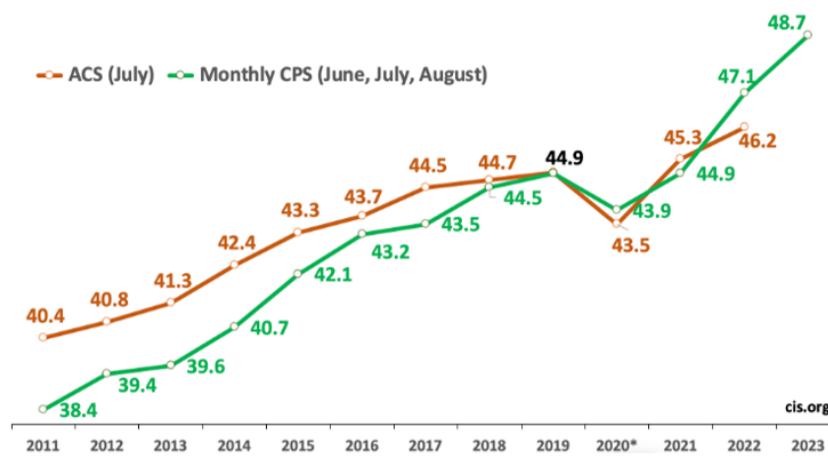
Source: Current Population Survey, *Basic Monthly CPS*, December 2023, <https://www.census.gov/data/datasets/time-series/demo/cps/cps-basic.2023.html#list-tab-1979780401>
US Census Bureau, American Community Survey (2022), Public Use Microdata Sample, <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/microdata/access.html>

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Apart from the decennial census, the US Census Bureau has two major surveys that can help track changing migration patterns on an annual basis. The first is the Current Population Survey (CPS), a continuous monthly survey randomly sampling about 60,000 households within the country that is used primarily for up-to-date information on employment conditions (e.g. the “monthly jobs report”). The second is the American Community Survey (ACS), a sort of annual mini-census, covering a much larger sample population (typically, over 3 million households) but usually appearing only once a year.

As we see in Figure 1, CPS and ACS offered significantly different estimates of net migration inflows to the United States even before the more statistically taxing Biden era surge in undocumented immigration was underway. According to the 2022 ACS, just under 2.2 million migrants were still in the USA out of the cohort who came to America in 2016-17. For that same period, however, the December 2023 CPS estimated just under 2.4 million—a discrepancy of about 200,000 or roughly 10 percent. The discrepancy was larger for the cohort of 2018-19: for them the gap was almost 400,000, with the CPS estimate about 18 percent higher than the ACS estimate. Differences in methodology—including sampling and weighting—help explain the discrepant results. Note that it is possible neither survey fully accounted for the magnitude of the net migration inflows during the years under consideration.

Figure 2: Can’t Get Their Story Straight
Contrasting US Census Bureau Estimates Of Foreign Born Population, In Millions



Source: American Community Survey, which reflects the population in July, and Center for Immigration Studies analysis of a combined sample of the June, July, and August public-use Current Population Survey.

Source: Steven A. Camarota and Karen Zeigler, “The Foreign-Born Share and Number at Record Highs in February 2024”, *Center for Immigration Studies*, March 28, 2024, <https://cis.org/Report/ForeignBorn-Share-and-Number-Record-Highs-February-2024>

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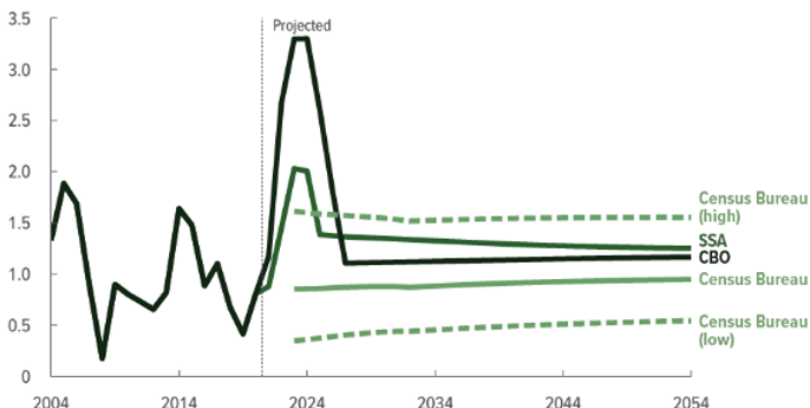
With different methodologies, the two main continuous demographic surveys from the US Census Bureau generated appreciably different estimates of levels and trends for the US foreign-born population in recent years. In the 2010s, ACS came up with consistently higher estimates than CPS for America’s immigrant population. After the Covid-19 pandemic, CPS estimates of America’s foreign-born population rose more rapidly than those of ACS. Steven Camarota and Karen Zeigler from the Center for Immigration Studies (CIS) prepared this chart, which should

stand as a cautionary against uncritical reliance on intra-censal numbers concerning America's foreign-born population from a single official demographic series.

Figure 3: Immigration Projections: Usually Wrong

CBO's and Other Agencies' Projections of Net Immigration

Millions of people



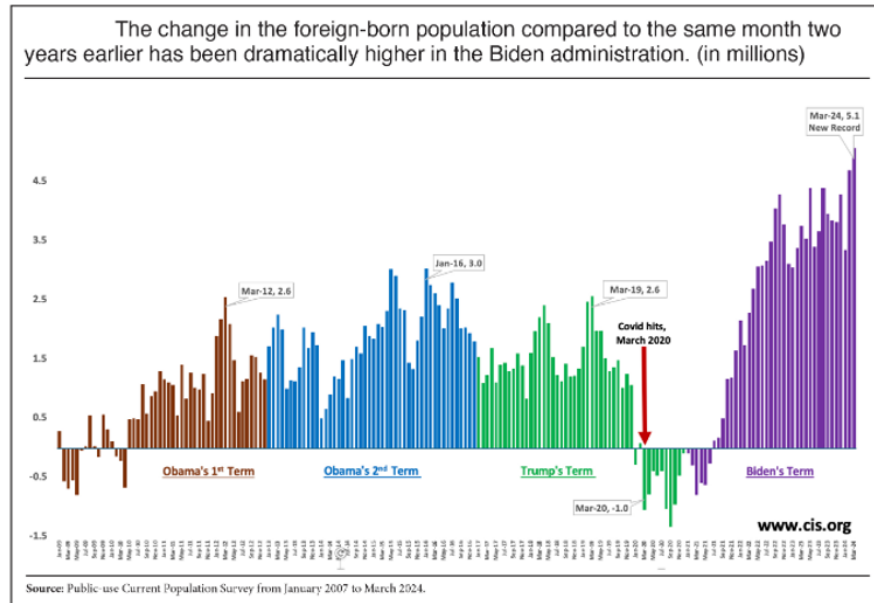
In the near term, CBO's projection of net immigration is higher than SSA's and the Census Bureau's projections. In later years, CBO's projection of net immigration is lower than SSA's but higher than the Census Bureau's projections in its main series.

Source: Congressional Budget Office, "The Demographic Outlook: 2024 to 2054", January, 2024, http://www.cbo.gov/publication/59899#_idTextAnchor013

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This Congressional Budget Office (CBO) chart highlights another vexing difficulty confounding estimates of immigration flows: bluntly stated, there is no reliable demographic technique for anticipating either immigration or emigration in advance. This is the case because the international movement of people is very largely driven by political and economic factors rather than demographic forces per se. To make matters even more problematic, demographic authorities tend to be highly 'risk averse' about adopting any assumption of changing future migration trajectories. As may be seen in this chart, the US Census Bureau's assumptions about future migration levels proceed essentially on 'autopilot'. The same is true for most other demographic agencies, and for migration projections generated for other countries all around the planet. In the real world, of course, net migration surges and slumps—but these changes in amplitude are generally recognized and dealt with (through revisions and adjustments) sometime after the fact. CBO "beat" the US Census Bureau on these projections because it was paying closer attention to developments along the Southern Border in the Biden era.

Figure 4: But The Biden Era Surge Shows Up In Official Statistics



Source: Steven A. Camarota and Karen Zeigler, "Foreign-Born Population Grew by 5.1 Million in the Last Two Years", Center for Immigration Studies, May 13, 2024, <https://cis.org/Report/ForeignBorn-Population-Grew-5-1-Million-Last-Two-Years>

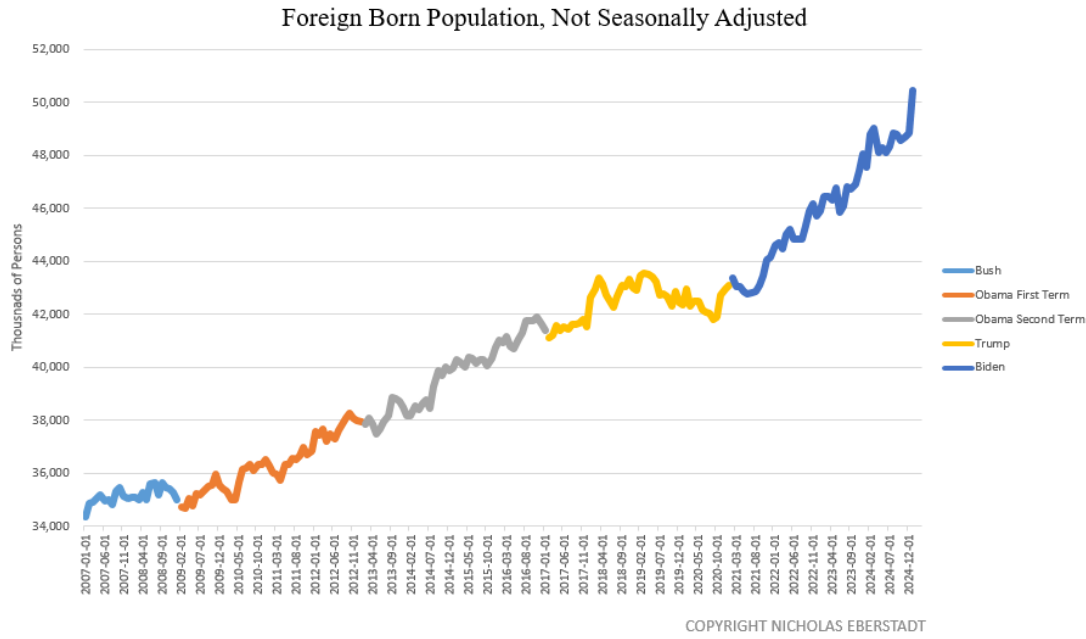
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CIS's Camarota and Zeigler offer this vivid chart to illustrate just how different the "Biden surge" in estimated net migration looks from trends immediately preceding. They use CPS monthly data for this—measuring net change in estimated foreign-born population in relation to the same month two years earlier.

One of the virtues of this chart is that it also reminds us that the foreign-born population can decline over time as well as rise. It is a dynamic process, with migrants constantly leaving as well as entering the USA. In addition, the natural survival trajectory associated with human aging means that some fairly regular proportion of the foreign-born can be expected to die each year. (Due to actuarial trends, this is in fact one of the most "predictable" demographic numbers relating to our immigrant population.)

During the Covid lockdowns and their attendant border clampdowns, America's total foreign-born population declined for over a year according to CPS estimates.

Figure 5: And These Recent Official Numbers May Well Be An Undercount



Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Population Level - Foreign Born [LNU00073395], retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis; <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/LNU00073395>, April 29, 2025.

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This chart tracking recently revised CPS monthly estimates of America’s foreign-born population again underscores the distinctive magnitude of the immigration influx during the Biden years.

We should bear in mind the possibility that these estimates for 2021 to the present (i.e., since the 2020 census) may still be an underestimate. CPS annual revisions of population (including foreign-born population) are attempts to “catch up with reality”. A sudden surge of undocumented immigration is intrinsically challenging to measure accurately given these randomized sampling techniques. Under these circumstances, net underestimation is much more likely than net overestimation for the foreign-born population.

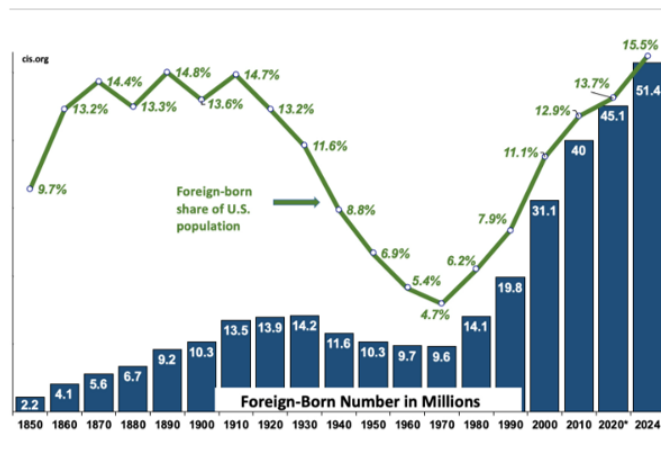


Figure 6:
America May Never Have Had
As High A Percentage Of Immigrants
In Our National Population
As It Does Currently

Source: Decennial Census for 1850 to 2000, American Community Survey for 2010 and 2020, February Current Population Survey for 2024.
 * The 2020 ACS shows only 43.5 million foreign-born residents — 13.2% of the population. However, the Census Bureau reports that it does not have confidence in the 2020 ACS due to pandemic related issues. Averaging the 2019 and 2021 ACS shows a foreign-born number that was 45.1 million and 13.7% of the population.

Source: Steven A. Camarota and Karen Zeigler, "The Foreign-Born Share and Number at Record Highs in February 2024", *Center for Immigration Studies*, March 28, 2024, <https://cis.org/Report/ForeignBorn-Share-and-Number-Record-Highs-February-2024>

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In 2024, according to CPS estimates, America's total foreign-born population surpassed the 50 million mark for the first time. No less significant, the CPS series indicates that the foreign-born now exceed 15 percent of the national population for the first time since such figures were first collected (in the 1850 census). The previous high water mark for percentage of foreign-born, as CIS' Camarota and Zeigler show here, was in 1890—during what we might call America's first wave of mass immigration, when the fraction peaked at 14.8 percent.

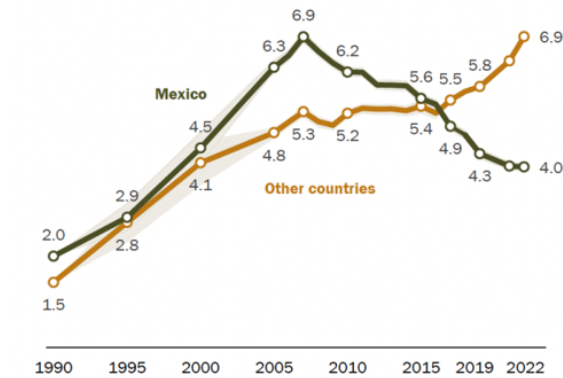
Note the prolonged decline in the US immigrant share of total population between 1910 and 1970. (Total US foreign-born numbers also experienced a long-term decline—and were actually lower in 1970 than in 1930.)

What happened? World War I interrupted the then-overwhelmingly European migration flows to the US (and other New World destinations). Then, in the 1920s, Congress enacted laws sharply restricting foreign immigration to the USA. Those laws remained on the books until the 1960s, when a liberalization of immigration legislation (and reforms greatly enhancing the opportunities of non-Europeans to qualify for US entry) set a new framework, with rules still largely in place today.

The immigration restrictions enacted in the 1920s reflected the deep unpopularity of mass immigration at that time among influential political constituencies. Strong anti-immigration sentiment had been evident in America since at least the 1890s; sweeping national restrictions on immigration were very nearly enacted in 1905. Mass immigration was associated in the contemporary mentality with the widening income and wealth gaps and depressed wages for less skilled native-born men that characterized the First Gilded Age. It is a reminder that stringent curbs on immigration have occurred in the USA before.

Mexicans have been a minority of unauthorized immigrants since 2017 but are by far the largest group

U.S. unauthorized immigrant population by country of birth, in millions



Note: Shading shows the range of the estimated 90% confidence interval. The data points marked are 1990, 1995, 2000, 2005, 2007, 2010, 2015, 2017 (crossover), 2019, 2021 and 2022.

Source: Pew Research Center estimates based on augmented U.S. Census Bureau data.

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Figure 7
The Rise And Fall Of Illegal Immigration
From Mexico

Source: Jeffrey S. Passel and Jens Manuel Krogstad, "What we know about unauthorized immigrants living in the U.S.," Pew Research Center, July 22, 2024, <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2024/07/22/what-we-know-about-unauthorized-immigrants-living-in-the-us/> 10

Jeffrey Passel and Jens Manuel Krogstad from the Pew Research Center used ACS data to estimate the stock and country origin of the US unauthorized immigrant population from 1990 to 2022. ACS estimates the number of both naturalized immigrants and a residual that includes both lawful permanent immigrants, such as green card holders, and those in the country illegally. Passel and Krogstad utilize additional data from immigration authorities plus their own statistical modeling to approximate the fraction of illegal entrants within that residual.

By these estimates the US illegal migrant population peaked around 2007 at somewhat more than 12 million and then gradually declined until 2019, reaching a low of just over 10 million, before beginning to rise again.

ACS-based Pew estimates suggest most illegal immigrants in the USA were Mexican from 1990 through 2015—but the total number of unauthorized migrants from Mexico is thought to have peaked in 2007, declining by over two fifths by 2022, by which point non-Mexicans accounted for over three fifths of the estimated stock of unauthorized immigrants in the USA.

Annual Border Patrol Migrant Apprehensions by Country at the U.S.-Mexico Border

2025 (Jan): Mexico 41% of total, Guatemala 13%, Honduras 8%, Colombia 7%, Venezuela 5%, Ecuador 3.9%, El Salvador 3.6%, All Others <3%
Since 2007: Mexico 48% of total, Guatemala 13%, Honduras 11%, El Salvador 5%, Venezuela 4%, All Others <3%

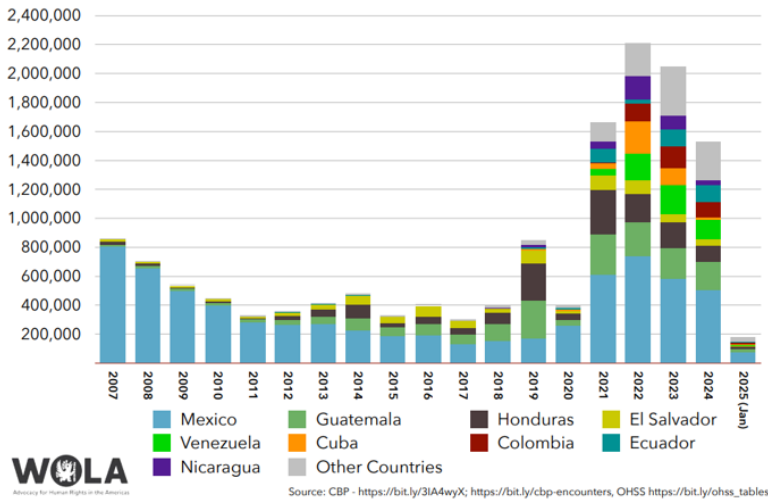


Figure 8
Mexico And Illegal Migration:
Once The Main Source,
Now Mainly A Global Gateway

Source: Washington Office on Latin America, "Some Graphics About the Border and Migration", Chart 6, Accessed April 29, 2025, https://borderoversight.org/files/wola_migration_charts.pdf 11

One imperfect but nonetheless telling indication of the volume and country of origin of illegal entrants to the US can be gleaned from annual US Customs and Border Protection (CBP) apprehensions on the Southern (i.e., US-Mexico) border, as reported by WOLA, the Washington Office on Latin America. (Data on apprehensions do not include would-be immigrants who were turned back as inadmissibles or expelled to the last country of transit for public health reasons, all of which are counted under CBP data on "encounters"—and of course these data do not include either the "gotaways" CBP agents sighted but did not apprehend, and the border crossers CBP never detected.)

As we see, Mexican nationals accounted for the overwhelming majority of apprehensions from 2007 through 2018. From 2021 through 2024, on the other hand, the great majority of apprehensions on the Southern Border were *not* Mexican nationals. Note that the "globalization" of illegal migration into the USA through the Southern border seems to have pre-dated the Biden Administration: 2019 was the first year in the WOLA/CBP data in which most apprehensions were not Mexican nationals.

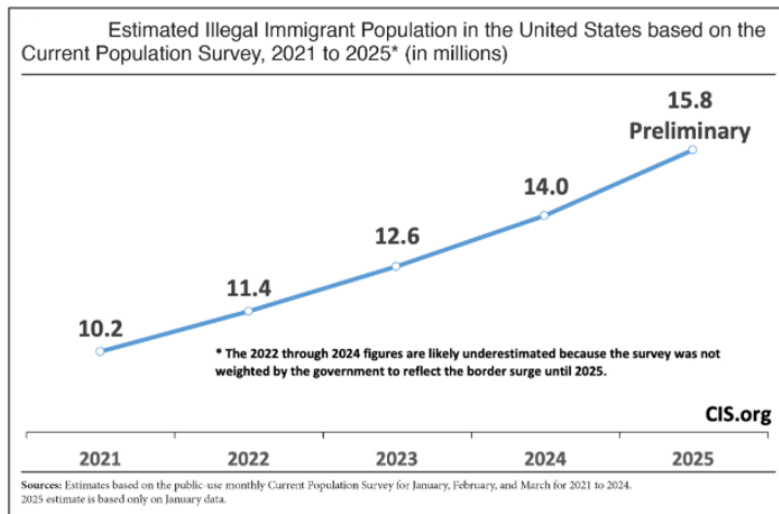


Figure 9

How Many Illegal Immigrants?

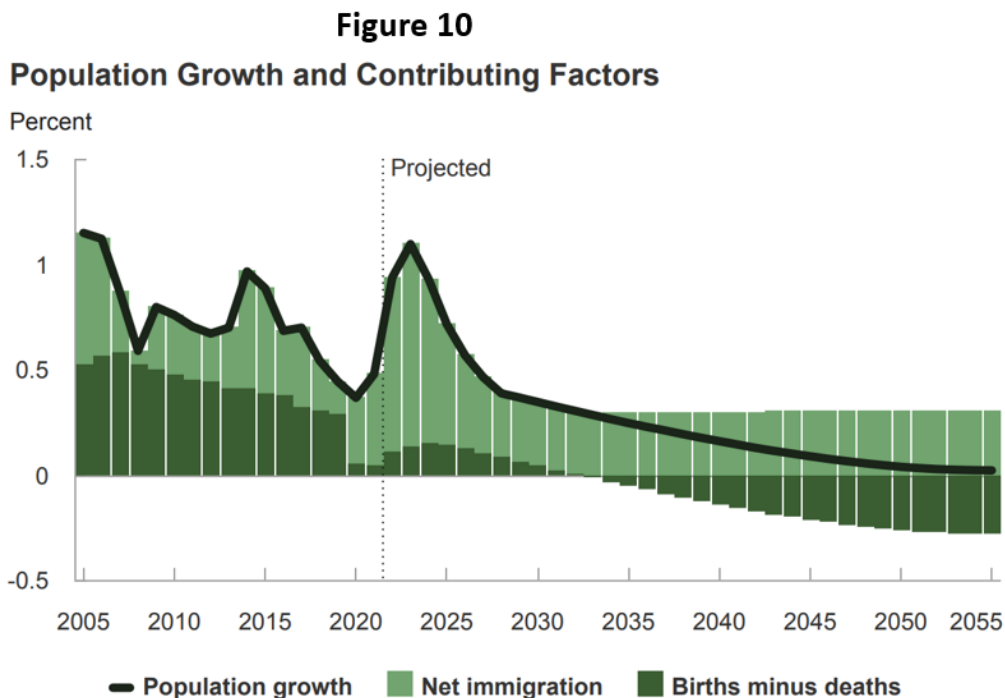
CIS's Camarota and Zeigler work with the CPS series to estimate levels and trends of unapproved migrants in the US during the Biden surge. Just as CPS currently offers a higher count of foreign-born population than ACS, their CPS-based estimates of unauthorized foreign-born population are higher than the ACS-based numbers in Figure 7.

Note that the pool of illegal immigrants in these estimates include many millions who did not enter the country through “regular” authorized channels but were accorded conditional protection through special policies, Presidential executive orders, or discretionary federal practices. The “unauthorized” but conditionally protected immigrant groups include the children and young adults with Deferred Action for Child Arrivals (DACA) protections; those with Temporary Protected Status (TPS) due to safety concerns in their home countries; asylum seekers; conditional protections for entrants from countries including Cuba, Haiti, Nicaragua, Venezuela, and Ukraine; and others. The Biden administration used its executive authority to expand many of these conditional protections between 2021 and 2025.

In January 2021, according to CPS, the US foreign-born population numbered roughly 43 million. By these numbers, just under a quarter of America's foreign-born would have been illegal migrants on the eve of the Biden surge. But these CIS estimates suggest that well over half of net migration during the Biden years might have been illegal (or unauthorized but conditionally accepted). Furthermore, it is possible that the total numbers of illegal migrants are *still* being underestimated in the CPS series, given discrepancies between CPS foreign-born population estimates and CBP numbers for 2021-25 on border encounters and so-called “gotaways”.

2) Without Immigration, US Labor Force Would Be Shrinking Now

Immigration plays an important role in the US economy today, and its significance is accentuated by America's own demographic trends. For roughly a generation—from the early 1980s until the Great Recession of 2008—the US fertility rate was very close to replacement, substantially higher than almost all other developed countries. Today the US fertility level is over 20 percent below the replacement level. All else equal, a continuation of such patterns would presage a shrinking of working age population, a surfeit of deaths over births, and eventually population decline—unless immigration compensated for domestic population shrinkage.



Source: Congressional Budget Office, "The Demographic Outlook: 2025 to 2055", January 13, 2025, <https://www.cbo.gov/publication/60875>

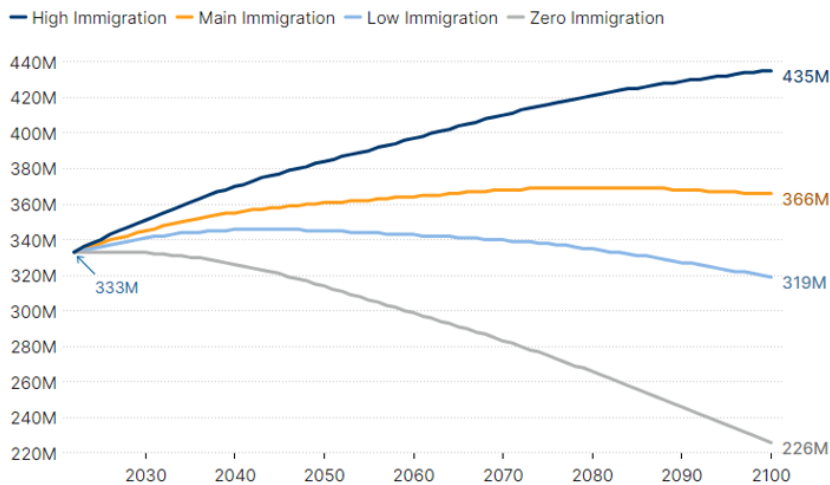
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The CBO's demographic estimates and projections caught the recent immigration surge sooner and better than other official US estimates—and as this CBO projection suggests, the US is currently on a path to "negative natural increase", where annual deaths regularly exceed annual births. Only continued immigration would forestall population decline after that.

Figure 11

Projected annual US population size, 2022-2100

Alternative immigration scenarios



Source: William H. Frey analysis of US Census Bureau projections, released November 9, 2023

Brookings Metro

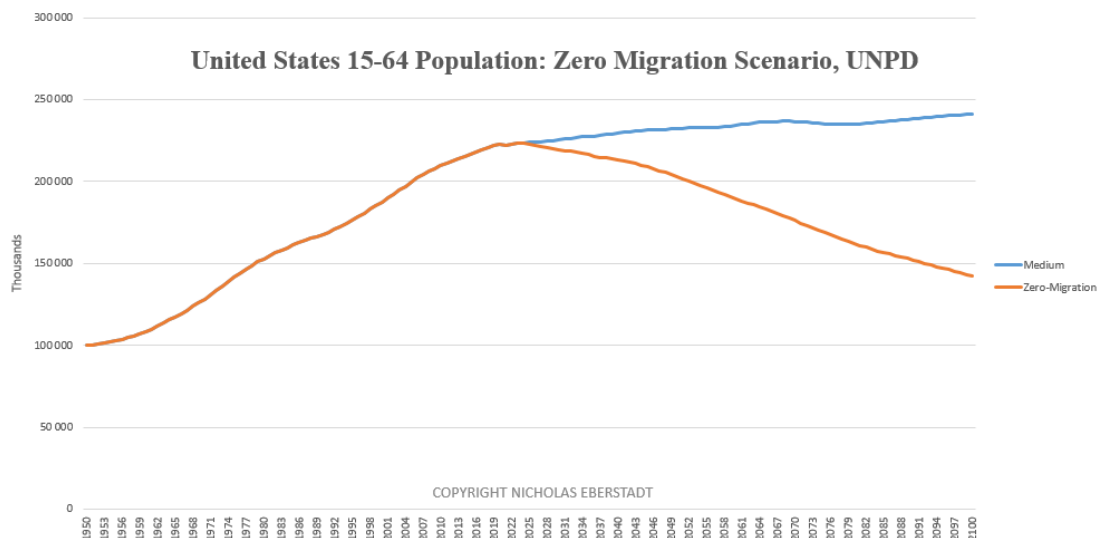
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Source: William H. Frey, "New census projections show immigration is essential to the growth and vitality of a more diverse US population", *The Brookings Institution*, November 29, 2023, <http://www.brookings.edu/articles/new-census-projections-show-immigration-is-essential-to-the-growth-and-vitality-of-a-more-diverse-us-population/>

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US Census Bureau projections, presented in this chart from the Brookings Institution's William H. Frey, underscore the same reality as the previous CBO projections. In fact, the Census Bureau's projections, like the CBO's, suggest that "negative natural increase" could commence as soon as 2033, in less than a decade.

Figure 12: Without Immigration, US Working-Age Population Would Be Falling Today



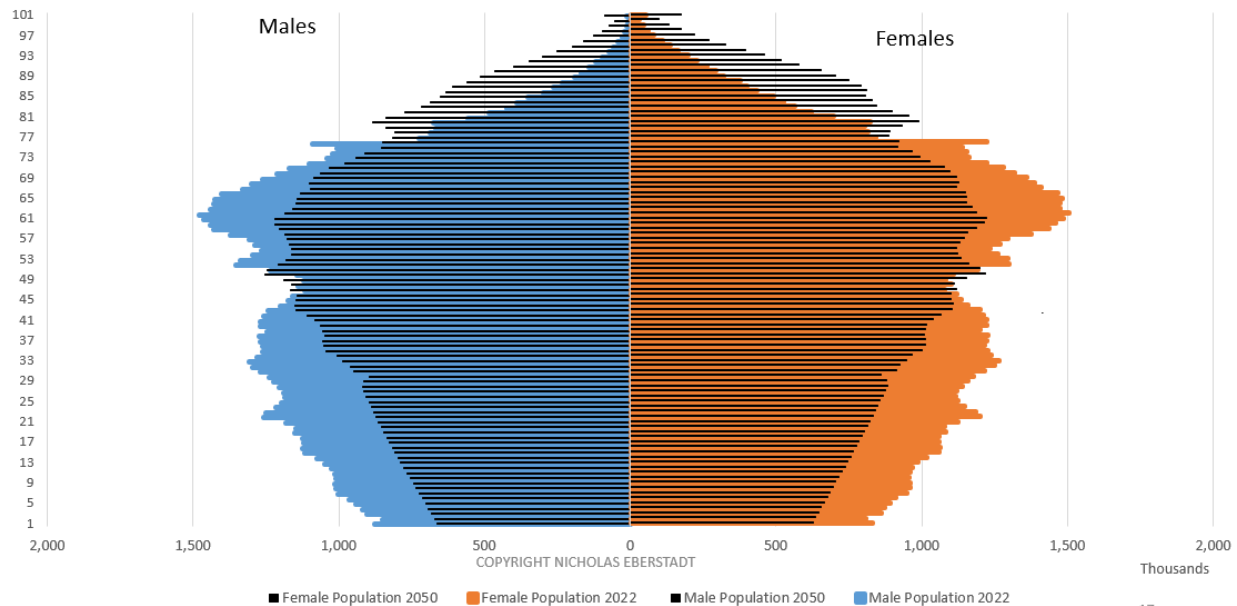
Source: United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2024). World Population Prospects 2024, Online Edition, <https://population.un.org/wpp/Download/Standard/Population/>.

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The United Nations Population Division, the world's premier international authority on global demographic trends, calculates that America's 15-64 age group—the broadest conventional

measure of working age population—would already be falling currently absent immigration inflows. The US Census Bureau’s current projections come to the same conclusion.

Figure 13: Projected Population for White Non-Hispanic Population, USA, 2022 v. 2050 (Census Bureau)



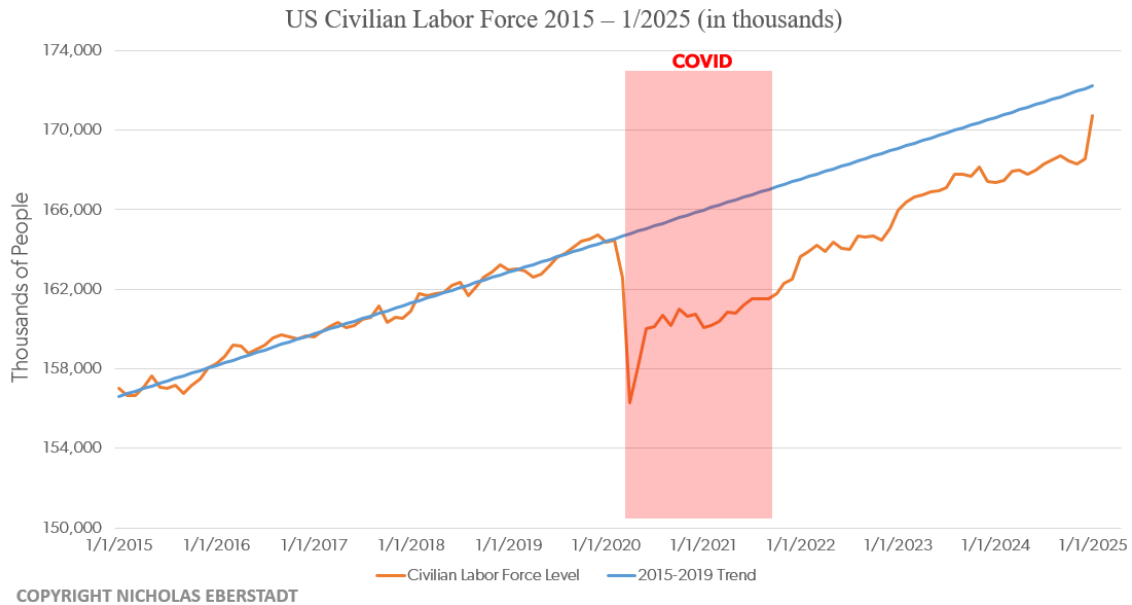
The US Non-Hispanic White “Anglo” population is a sort of proxy for what the US would look like without immigration, since only 4% of them are foreign-born. Currently, the US Anglo population structure looks roughly like Europe today. By 2050, on current US Census Bureau projections, it would look more like today’s Japan: which is the grayest national population yet registered.

Only the 75+ group grows for the Anglos over the next generation. And overall population declines by 15 percent by 2050.

3) Native-born Labor Can't Fill the Demand for Jobs in America

Both legal and illegal immigration are integral to the operation of the US economy as we currently know it. This basic truth is not always appreciated in today's debates about immigration. The following charts detail this reality.

Figure 14: Where Are All The Workers?

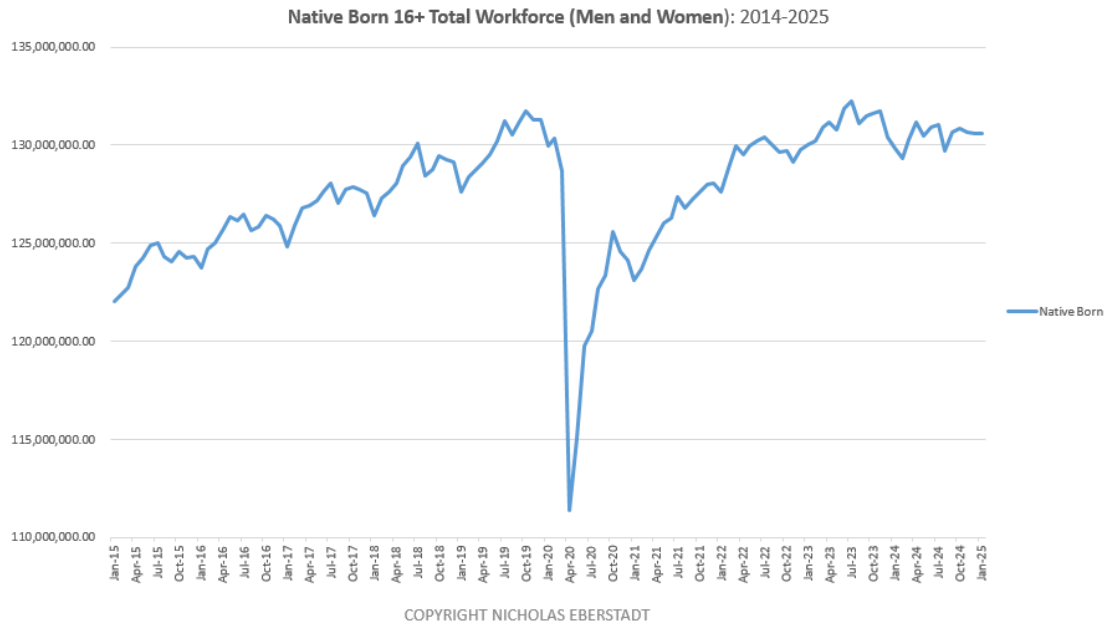


Sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Civilian Labor Force Level [CLF160V], retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis; <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CLF160V>, date accessed: March 6, 2025; figures are seasonally adjusted.

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During Covid-19 the US labor force, which had been growing steadily, was knocked off course. Five years after the pandemic it has yet to recover fully—notwithstanding the post-pandemic surge in illegal immigration.

Figure 15: Native Born Labor Peters Out

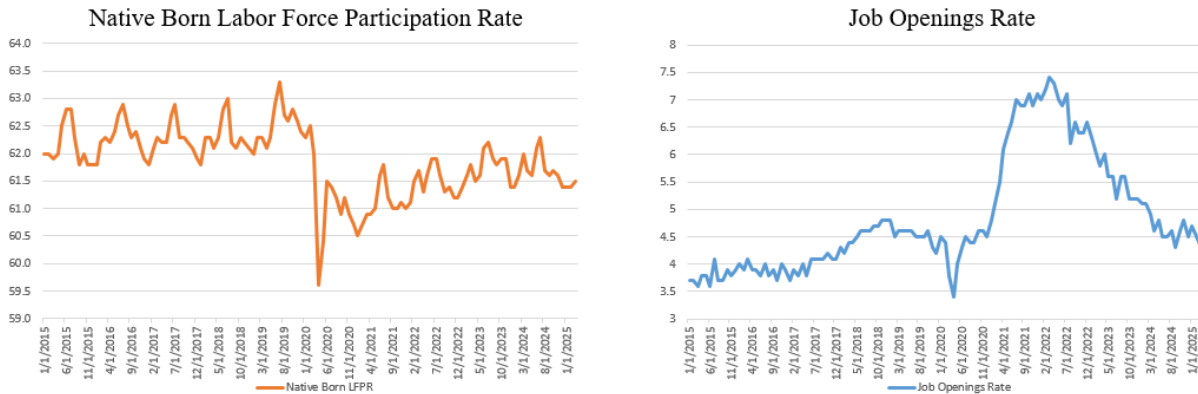


Source: Current Population Survey, Basic Monthly CPS, <https://www.census.gov/data/datasets/time-series/demo/cps/cps-basic-2024.html#list-tab-1979780401>

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America's native-born workforce numbers have stagnated since the Covid-19 pandemic. In early 2025, according to CPS, the total native-born workforce was about one million below its 2019 pre-Covid peak. The demography of America's native-born population is a major factor here—but as we will see, declining labor force participation rates for the US native-born labor force are also an important influence on this new emerging trend.

Figure 16: The Mystery of Native Born Labor Force Participation Rates

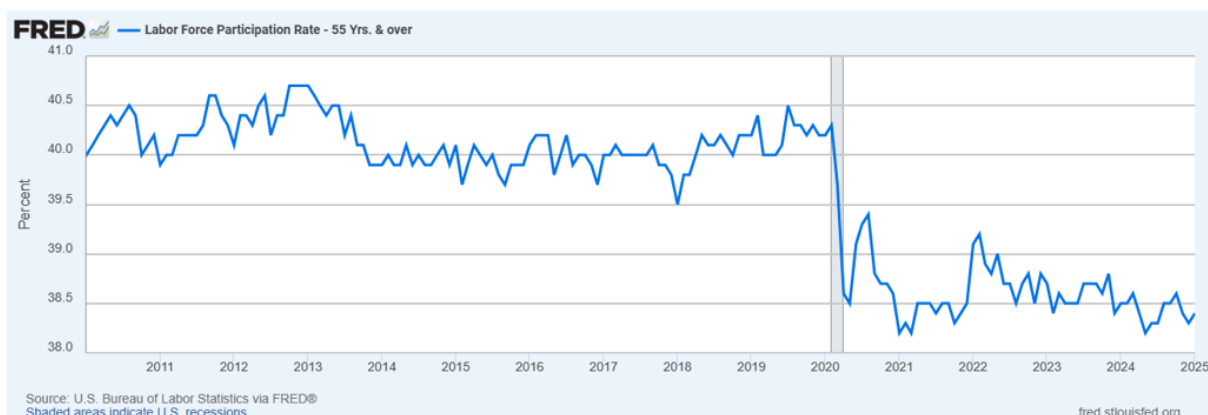


Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey, "Job Openings Rate", Series ID JTS0000000000000000J0R
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Labor Force Participation Rate - Native Born [LNU01373413], retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis;
<https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/LNU01373413>, April 30, 2025.

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Labor force participation patterns were fairly stable on the eve of the Covid-19 pandemic—but they fell sharply during the initial months of that crisis and have yet to recover. The faltering recovery is all the more curious in light of the unprecedented peacetime labor shortage that emerged post-Covid. In 2022, according the Bureau of Labor Statistics, the number of unfilled open positions was as high as 12 million—but this enormous demand for workers did not seem to draw native-born men and women back into the labor force. If the 2019 native-born labor force participation rate were still in effect, America would have had almost two and a half million additional native-born men and women in the labor force in early 2025.

Figure 17: Help, I've Fallen Down And I Can't Get Up
55+ Labor Participation Rates: USA 2010-2025



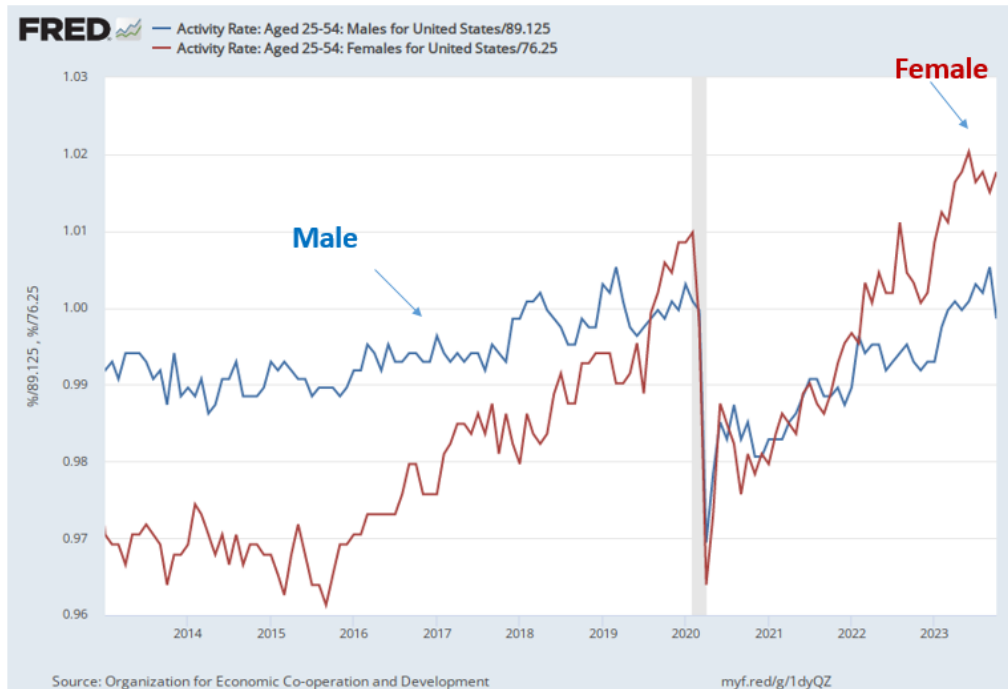
Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Labor Force Participation Rate - 55 Yrs. & over [LNS11324230],
retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis; <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/LNS11324230>

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One of the relatively bright spots in the US labor market picture over the past generation was the rising rates of employment and labor force participation for older Americans (those 55 and older). But the Covid crisis delivered a shock to the older workforce from which it has not yet recovered. The early 2025 55+ workforce would have been nearly 2 million smaller than it would have been at 2019 LFPR rates.

Figure 18: Prime Age Male Fail

Relative LFPRs, 2013-2023: Prime Age Male vs Prime Age Female (2019 = 100)

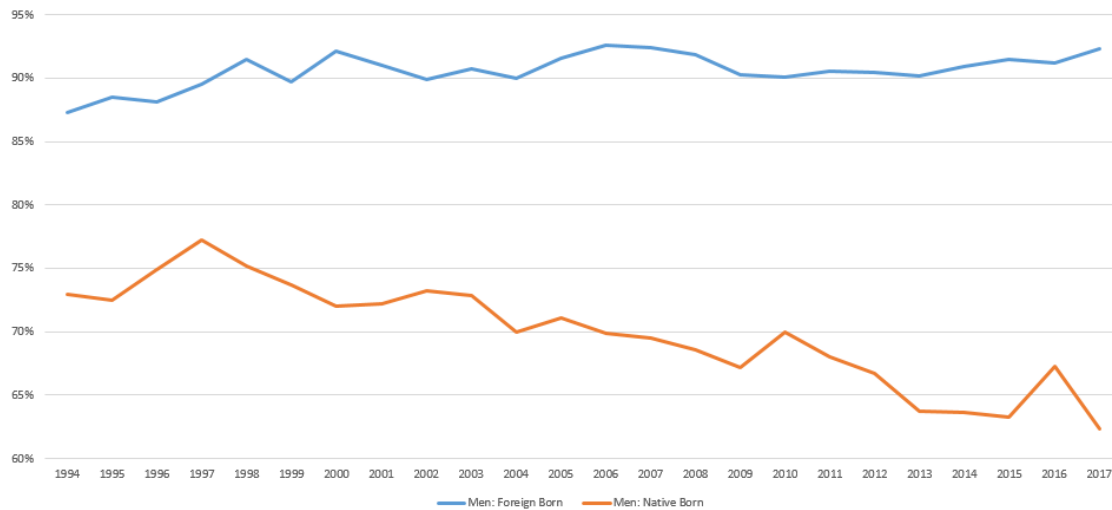


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Workforce participation rates for men of prime working age (25-54) have been declining in the USA since the 1960s. This is almost entirely due to a falloff in labor force participation for native-born men. This chart shows the tepid snap-back in workforce participation after Covid for prime age men in comparison to prime age women. The chart includes both foreign and native-born workers; a chart for native-born workforce would likely accentuate the disparity highlighted here.

Figure 19: Not All High School Dropouts Are Disadvantaged
 Labor Force Participation Rates for Native and Foreign Born Prime Age
 Men With Less than a High School Education (1994-2017)



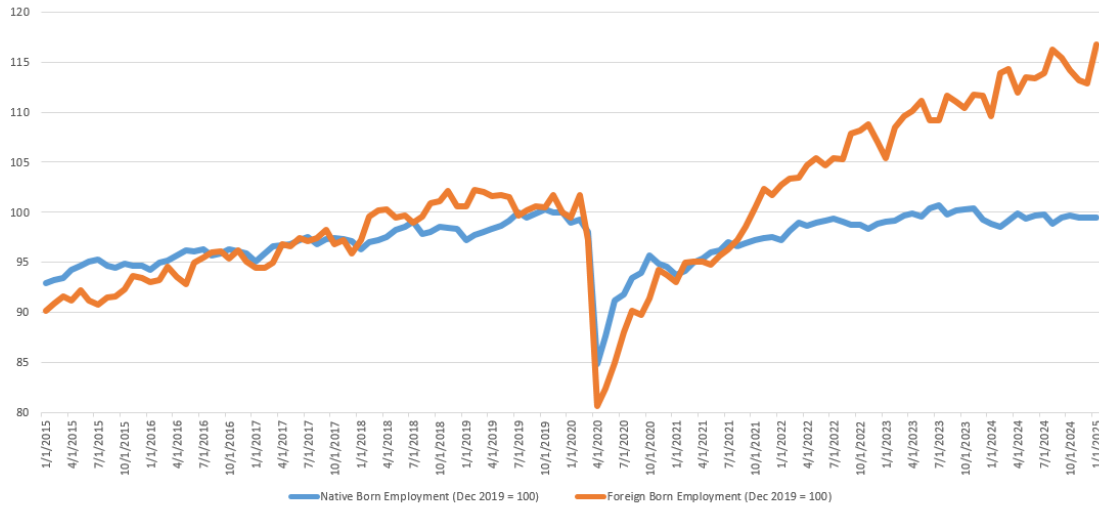
Notes: Sarah Flood, Miriam King, Renae Rodgers, Steven Ruggles, and J. Robert Warren. Integrated Public Use Microdata Series, Current Population Survey: Version 6.0 [dataset]. Minneapolis, MN: IPUMS, 2018. <https://doi.org/10.18128/D030.V65.0>, accessed September 7, 2018

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Received wisdom holds that structural and technological changes in the modern economy have disadvantaged workers with lower levels of educational attainment. That generalization, however, fails to recognize the heterogeneity of our low-education workforce—and the very different labor market outcomes for distinct sub-groups within it. This chart highlights the enormous gap in LFPRs for prime age males without high school degrees, depending on whether they were born abroad or in the United States. By 2017 that gap had widened to almost 30 percentage points. Over ninety percent of foreign-born prime male high school dropouts were working or looking for work—a rate not too different from native-born prime male college graduates in the USA.

Figure 20: Relative Employment Growth 2015-2025,
Native Born vs Foreign Born (Dec 2019 = 100)

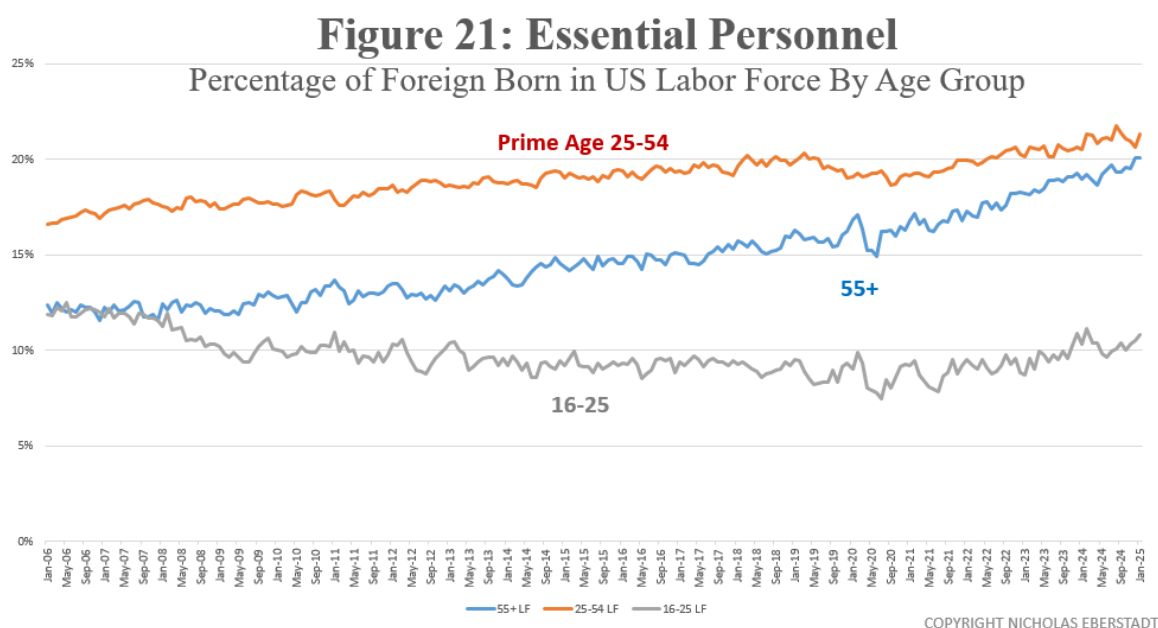


Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Level - Native Born [LNU02073413], retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis;
<https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/LNU02073413>, April 29, 2025.
 U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Level - Foreign Born [LNU02073395], retrieved from FRED, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis;
<https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/LNU02073395>, April 29, 2025.

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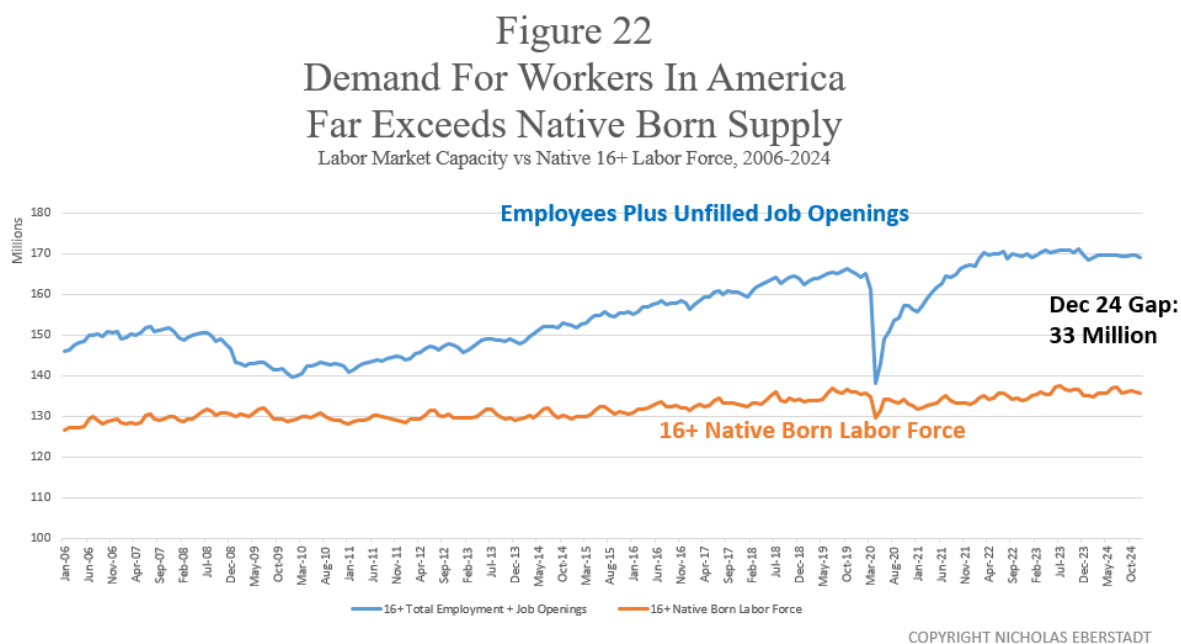
The labor market performance of foreign-born workers and native-born workers has diverged dramatically since the Covid pandemic. The overwhelming majority of employees in America are native-born—yet there were just 1.3 million more native-born job holders at the start of 2025 than in the year 2019. By contrast, America’s much smaller pool of foreign-born workers as of January 2025 registered a gain of about 4.7 million jobs in relation to 2019—close to four times as much growth in absolute terms. While the reasons for this shift can be debated, it is clear that US employers are coming to rely increasingly on foreign-born labor.



Source: Current Population Survey, Basic Monthly CPS, <https://www.census.gov/data/datasets/time-series/demo/cps/cps-basic-2024.html#list-tab-1979780401>

26

Most Americans are not aware of how significant foreign-born labor has become within the US workforce. By early 2025, over one in five members of the prime age-workforce—men and women 25 to 54 years of age—was an immigrant. No less striking: a fifth of the 55-plus workforce was foreign-born as well. (The fraction remains much lower for the 16-24 group, but it accounts for only about an eighth of the overall American workforce.)



Source: Current Population Survey, Basic Monthly CPS, <https://www.census.gov/data/datasets/time-series/demo/cps/cps-basic-2024.html#list-tab-1979780401>

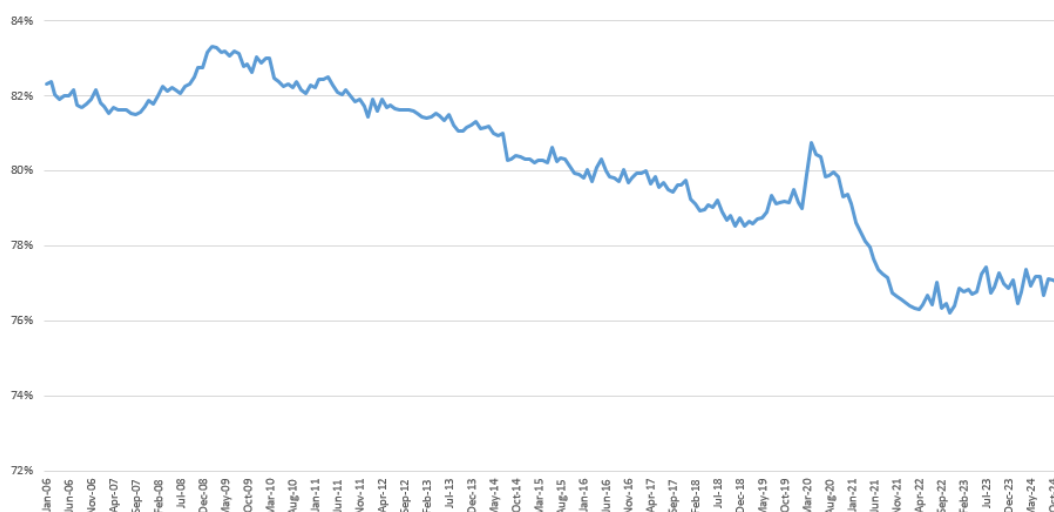
Bureau of Labor Statistics, Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey, "Job openings level, Total nonfarm, seasonally adjusted" - JTS00000000000000000000JOL, <https://data.bls.gov/pdq/SurveyOutputServlet>

27

The demand for workers in the US economy is the sum of unfilled job openings plus paid positions filled by current employees. We compare that trend for “demand” with the native-born workforce “supply”. Business cycle fluctuations and sudden “shocks” (Covid) notwithstanding, it is apparent that a widening gap has gradually opened between the demand for work in America and the native-born workers willing to fill it. At the end of 2024, the gap between these measures of demand and supply was about 33 million: a very large number in relation to the 136 million native-born men and women in the labor force at that same time.

Figure 23: Likely Lower Than Ever Before

Percent of US Job Market Demand Filled by Native Born
2006-2024



Source: Current Population Survey, Basic Monthly CPS, <https://www.census.gov/data/datasets/time-series/demo/cps/cps-basic-2024.html#list-tab-1979780401>
Bureau of Labor Statistics, Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey, “Job openings level, Total nonfarm, seasonally adjusted” - JTS0000000000000000JOL, <https://data.bls.gov/pdq/SurveyOutputServlet> 28

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This chart shows the proportion of native-born employees in relation to total paid employees and unfilled jobs in the US labor market. By this measure, native-born workers accounted for just 77 percent of the labor market’s total demand for workers at the end of 2024.

Native-born workers meet less of overall job demand in our post-Covid economy than at any previous point on record.

Note that our modern employment statistics system was not developed until the final years of the Great Depression—so we lack corresponding figures for our first era of mass immigration.

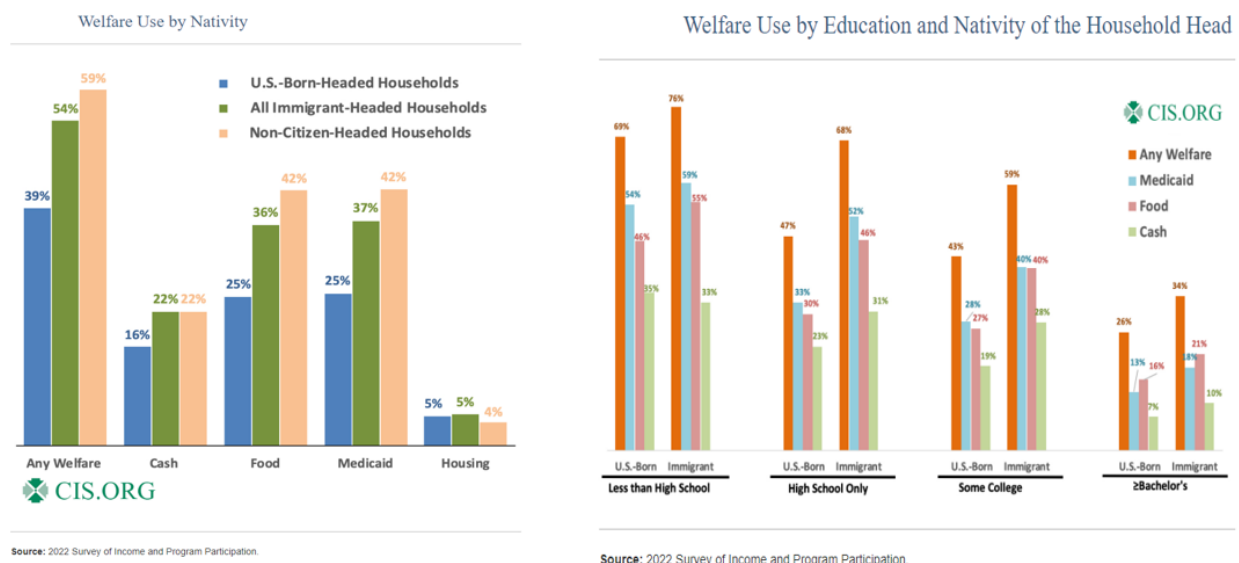
Even so, it seems quite possible that today’s ratio of native-born employees to total demand for work in the national economy might be lower than ever before in US history. Put another way: our contemporary economy may be more dependent on foreign labor—work from both legal and illegal migrants—than ever before in US history.

4) Underestimated: The Economic and Social Costs of Immigration/Illegal

Immigration

As we have seen, foreign-born labor plays an unprecedented role in the US economy nowadays. We do not think we need to make the case that economic benefits accruing from that immigrant labor are consequential—we tend to regard this as self-evident, given our free market system. But some of the social and economic costs of immigration, and especially illegal immigration, deserve more attention.

Figure 24



CIS's Camarota and Zeigler use the Census Bureau's Survey on Income and Program Participation (SIPP) to examine reported incidence of welfare (means-tested benefits) by native-born and immigrant headed households in the year 2022. They found households headed by immigrants were more likely to rely on means-tested benefits than those headed by the native-born—with non-citizens' households most likely to be dependent. Interestingly, this finding does not appear to be simply an artifact reflecting socioeconomic disparities between the native-born and the foreign-born. At every level of educational attainment and for every means-tested program under consideration, use of public benefits was higher in households headed by immigrants than in those headed by the native-born.

Immigrants are more likely to be in the workforce than their native-born counterparts—but it seems they are also more likely to be dependent on means-tested benefits, too. We do not have data for illegal immigrants' public benefit use, but non-citizen immigrants—a category including both green card holders and unauthorized/irregular entrants—are more likely to apply for and receive means-tested benefits than US citizen households, be they native-born or naturalized.

Figure 25

Today's Workers Are Tomorrow's Retirees



Source: Migration Policy Institute, "Age-Sex Pyramids of U.S. Immigrant and Native-Born Populations, 1970-Present", <https://www.migrationpolicy.org/programs/data-hub/charts/age-sex-pyramids-immigrant-and-native-born-population-over-time>

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As these population pyramids from the Migration Policy Institute illustrate, the age structure of both the native-born and foreign-born populations in America have changed dramatically since 1980.

The major entitlement programs in the US federal budget are the old-age pension and health programs—Social Security and Medicare. Today's immigrant population is more youthful than the native-born population by most metrics, but today's workers will be tomorrow's retirees. Some categories of immigrants are more likely to be net contributors to these social programs: those who arrive well educated and relatively young, and enjoy long employment careers. Others are more likely to be net Social Security and Medicare recipients: these include immigrants with limited education (and lifetime earnings) and relatively long lives (and retirement benefits). In highly stylized terms, the former category is more descriptive of legal immigrants, while the latter is more descriptive of illegal immigrants.

Figure 26: Estimated Fiscal Impact of Foreign Born By Age and Education

Manhattan Institute: Di Martino (2024)

Impact Relative to Natives

Average immigrant: \$266,982

Age at arrival	Less than high school	High school	Some college	Bachelor's degree	Graduate degree
0-17	-\$39,953	-\$66,925	\$146,408	\$598,282	\$1,049,074
18-24	-\$58,209	\$47,874	\$148,879	\$569,340	\$1,423,680
25-34	-\$65,436	\$4,521	\$125,398	\$534,300	\$1,195,637
35-44	-\$93,582	-\$14,396	\$114,748	\$253,898	\$835,537
45-54	-\$149,401	-\$73,987	\$52,362	\$157,741	\$403,740
55-64	-\$185,891	-\$105,731	-\$71,186	-\$7,079	\$116,058
65+	-\$149,889	-\$133,271	-\$29,979	-\$73,607	\$135,689

Cato: Bier (2024)

Lifetime fiscal effect of the average new immigrant in 2024 by age and education, according to the Manhattan Institute fiscal impact model, with and without revisions

Ages	No High School	High School	Some College	Bachelor's	Advanced	Total
0-17	-\$127,295	-\$76,590	\$165,868	\$834,109	\$1,694,553	\$616,124
18-24	\$44,856	\$104,867	\$300,470	\$1,112,632	\$2,480,093	\$946,675
25-34	\$14,928	\$48,119	\$272,322	\$1,015,238	\$2,277,470	\$849,926
35+	-\$362,988	-\$272,873	-\$193,986	\$1,344,724	\$2,273,510	\$631,360
All with revisions	-\$103,087	-\$12,779	\$91,971	\$843,315	\$1,849,784	\$626,602
MI headline	-\$338,023	-\$271,606	-\$136,611	\$193,967	\$873,363	\$10,616

Source: Authors calculations based on Daniel Di Martino, "The Lifetime Fiscal Impact of Immigrants" Manhattan Institute, September 19, 2024; and Cato Institute's calculations using U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey, 2023 Annual Social and Economic Supplement; U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis, National Income and Product Accounts (NIPA), U.S. Department of Commerce, 2024; Congressional Budget Office, "Budget and Economic Data," 2024.
Notes: Manhattan Institute Table 15. The age structure of new immigrants from CPS ASEC, using 1) noncitizens who 2) entered the US from 2022-24 and 3) migrated in the last year.

Source: Daniel Di Martino, "The Lifetime Fiscal Impact of Immigrants", Table 16, *Manhattan Institute*, September 19, 2024, <https://manhattaninstitute.org/article/the-lifetime-fiscal-impact-of-immigrants>
David J. Bier, "Manhattan Institute's 'Lifetime Fiscal Impact of Immigrants' Report Shows Upside to Immigration", Table A, *Cato Working Paper*, November 13, 2024, <https://www.cato.org/sites/cato.org/files/2024-11/working-paper-82-update.pdf>

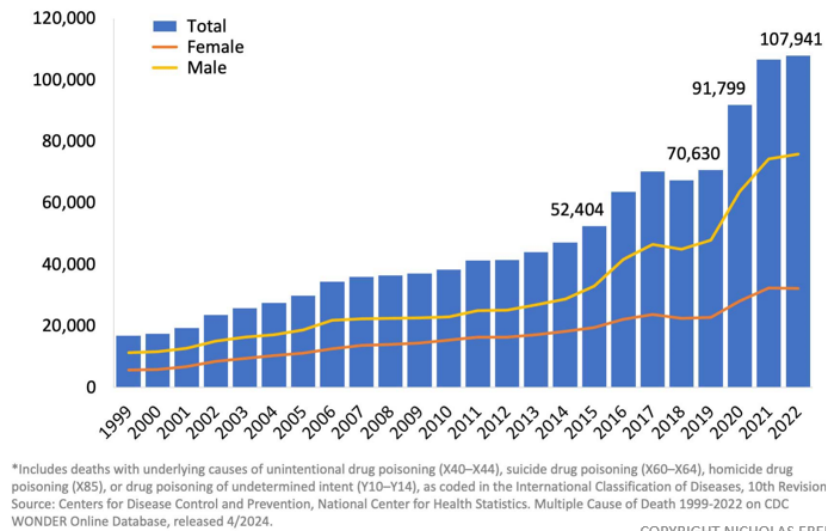
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There is considerable disagreement about the fiscal impact of immigration in the USA. There is little doubt that the net impact depends upon the age and educational attainment of immigrants. But calculating net present value of income, tax revenue, and public benefit streams is devilishly difficult: not only for reasons of modeling complexity, but for the assumptions embodied. As we see here, Daniel DiMartino of Manhattan Institute and David Bier of Cato Institute arrive at dramatically different estimates of the net fiscal impact of immigration by age and education of immigrant cohorts—even though their work commences at the same starting point and relies on the same data sources. Both agree, however, that migrants with no more than a high school degree, when taken as a whole, cost the country more in public benefits than they contribute in taxes.

Figure 27

U.S. Overdose Deaths* by Sex, 1999-2022



Source: National Institute on Drug Abuse, "Drug Overdose Deaths: Facts and Figures", August 21, 2024, <https://nida.nih.gov/research-topics/trends-statistics/overdose-death-rates>

33

Another social consequence of an open border: increasing overdose deaths due to illicit import of fentanyl across the Southern Border. Just how much of the spike in overdose deaths after 2020 can be attributed to loosened border controls is a question that merits further investigation.

We have not been able to locate accurate numbers on human trafficking and other crimes associated with the loosening of border controls in 2021-24, but readers should also be mindful of these difficult-to-quantify consequences as well.

5) Southern Border Crisis Era Migrants: Less Educated/Skilled than Other

Immigrants

The surge in illegal/conditionally protected immigration in the Biden era certainly lowered the overall educational and skills profile of the new wave of entrants into the USA in the 2021-24 period. There are longstanding major and characteristic differences between the educational profiles of traditionally processed legal immigrants and illegal immigrants (including those who obtained conditional permission to remain in the US during the Biden era).

We may also wonder whether the extraordinary recent surge in illegal migration had an impact on the profile of the new wave of illegal entrants themselves. In other words: did this unusual influx reduce educational attainment, labor force participation, and earnings of Biden era illegal entrants in relation to previous cohorts of illegal entrants?

Figure 28
Disparities In Educational Attainment By Region of Origin:
US Foreign Born Adults 25 And Older, 2022 (ACS)

2022		
Legal Immigration = High-Skill Profile	<u>Percent Less</u>	<u>Percent</u>
	<u>than High</u>	<u>Bachelor's or</u>
	<u>School</u>	<u>Higher</u>
Native Born	7.2	35.9
Foreign Born		
--Of Which:		
--Latin American	37.8	17.3
--All Others	11.9	52.0

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Source: Shabnam Shenazi Azari, Virginia Jenkins, Joyce Hahn, and Lauren Medina, "The Foreign-Born Population in the United States: 2022", American Community Survey Briefs, April, 2024, <http://www2.census.gov/library/publications/2024/demo/acsbr-019.pdf>

35

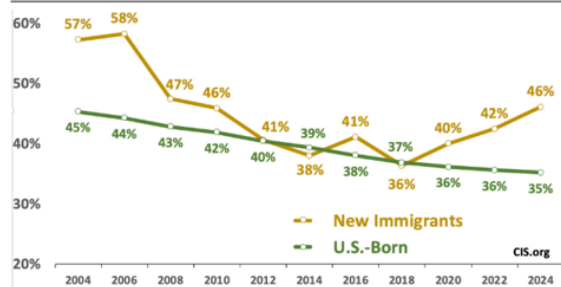
This chart, derived from ACS 2022 data, highlights the striking differences in educational attainment for US immigrants from Latin America and those from the rest of the world. Immigrant adults from Latin America are over five times more likely to lack a bachelor's degree than their native-born counterparts. On the other hand, foreign-born adults born outside Latin America are half again as likely to have completed higher education as native-born Americans.

This chart covers migrants of all legal statuses—it does not distinguish between naturalized citizens, those with green cards or long-term permanent residents, and others. But we know that the overwhelming majority of today's illegal immigrants to the US were born in Latin America and the Caribbean, and that illegal or conditionally protected immigrants account for about half of all New World immigrants in the United States today. We may reasonably infer that the

educational profile of illegal entrants from Latin America is even lower than the average for the Latin American immigrant population.

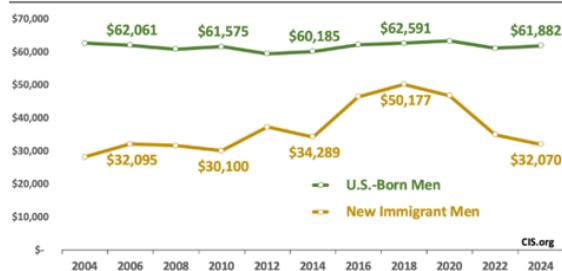
Figure 29: Educational Attainment And Income For New Migrants Tracks With Illegal Migrant Flows

After matching the U.S.-born from 2012 to 2018, the share of newly arrived adult immigrants with no education beyond high school increased significantly, creating a large gap with the U.S.-born.



Sources: Public-use October/November/December Current Population Survey (CPS). Figures are for adults 18 and older. In even-numbered years new arrivals in the CPS include the current year and the two prior years.

The median annual earnings of newly arrived adult immigrant men improved some after 2010, but has deteriorated in absolute terms and relative to U.S.-born men in recent years. (in 2024 dollars)



Sources: Public-use Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement (CPS ASEC). In even-numbered years new arrivals in the CPS ASEC include the current year and the two prior years. Figures are for employed adult men 18 and older. The survey asks about earnings in the prior calendar year.

Source: Steven A. Camarota and Karen Zeigler, "The Declining Education Level of Newly Arrived Immigrants", Center for Immigration Studies, February 19, 2025, <https://cis.org/Report/Declining-Education-Level-Newly-Arrived-Immigrants>

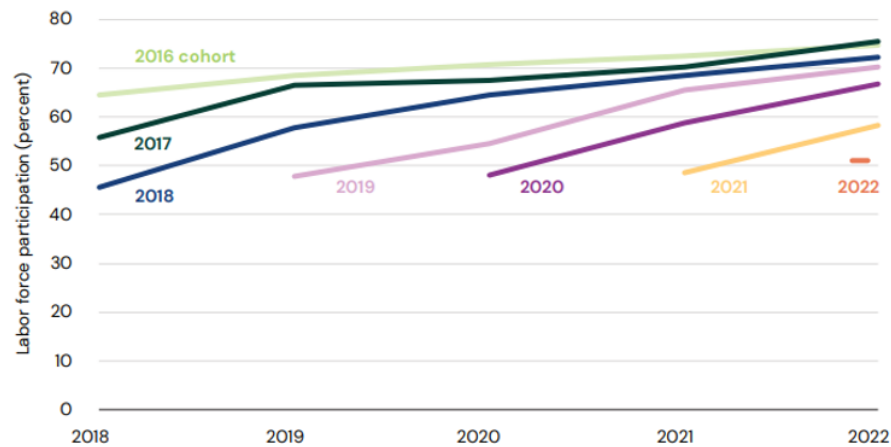
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Illegal immigration continued to rise steadily from the 1990s until the Great Recession of 2008, when opportunities for employment fell off sharply. Illegal migration began to surge once more after 2020. Unsurprisingly, the educational attainment of newly-arrived foreign-born adults rose markedly with the Great Recession but began to fall again in the Southern Border Crisis years, as CIS's Camarota and Zeigler demonstrate. They also show that real earnings for newly arrived male immigrants rose significantly in the wake of the Great Recession, but plunged during the illegal immigration surge of the Biden years.

Figure 30: Will these lines converge eventually?

Labor force participation among immigrants ages 16+, by immigrant cohort, 2018–22



Source: BLS/ACS 2018–22.

Note: Rates reflect labor force participation of foreign-born individuals aged 16 and up based on reported cohort year of arrival in the U.S., as observed in different survey years.

THE HAMILTON PROJECT
BROOKINGS

Source: Wendy Edelberg and Tara Watson, “New immigration estimates help make sense of the pace of employment”, *The Hamilton Project*, March 2024, http://www.brookings.edu/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/20240307_ImmigrationEmployment_Paper.pdf

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Wendy Edelberg and Tara Watson of the Brookings Institution’s Hamilton Project show that labor force participation rates tend to rise in the years after arrival for every new annual “class” of immigrants between 2016 and 2022—a finding in keeping with the processes of adjustment for newcomers to the United States. They argue that LFPRs for new waves of migrants are likely to converge over time as new entrants assimilate.

This may prove to be the case. On the other hand, we may wonder if the special circumstances of 2021–2024 created new and somewhat different conditions in the pool of illegal entrants. As we have seen already, ACS seems to “miss” some of the newly arrived migrants in its survey, at least in relation to CPS—and we do not know yet just how large the CPS undercount may be. Following the demographic characteristics and the economic trajectory of the latest surge of illegal immigrants into the USA would be a fruitful research project for the years ahead.

6) Venezuela Agonistes: Only a Small Taste for USA – So Far

The surge of immigration from Venezuela became a flashpoint in the 2024 Presidential election campaign. This particular inflow may deserve attention in its own right for that reason.

Figure 31
Venezuela: UNHCR Assessment, December 2023

More than 7.7 million people have left Venezuela in search of protection and a better life. The majority – more than 6.5 million people – have been hosted in Latin American and Caribbean countries

Source: United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, "Emergency Appeal: Venezuela Situation", <https://www.unhcr.org/us/emergencies/venezuela-situation>

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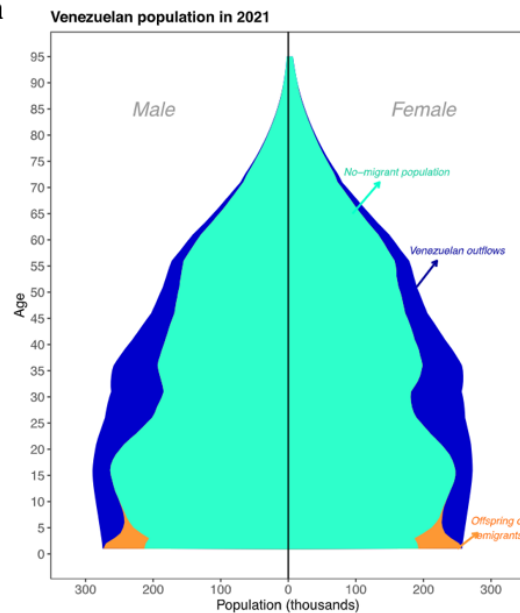
Venezuela has suffered man-made calamity under its strongman ruler, Nicholas Maduro. Since he came to power in 2013, the country's economy has collapsed, with GDP plunging by two thirds or more between 2013 and 2020 according to various estimates. (GDP remains far lower than in 2013 to this writing.) Economic devastation and the political recklessness that precipitated it have prompted many millions of Venezuelans to flee their homeland.

As of year-end 2023, the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) estimated that the overwhelming majority of this Venezuelan exodus was currently settled in other Latin American countries, with some living in Caribbean countries as well.

Figure 32
The Demography of Mass Emigration

“The recent Venezuelan exodus represents the largest displacement of people in Latin American history, comparable in magnitude to the 2015 crisis in war-torn Syria when 23 percent of Syrian nationals fled to neighboring nations.”

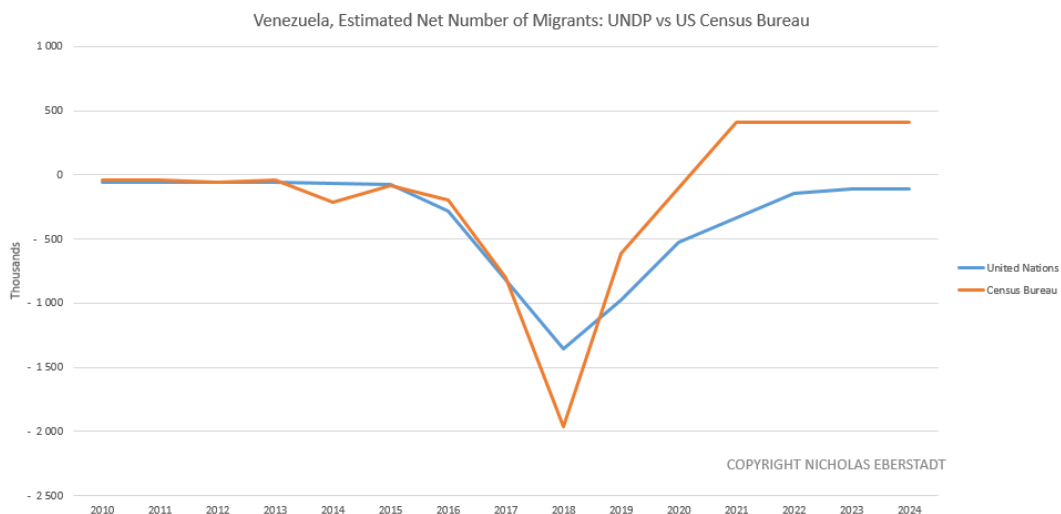
Jenny Garcia Arias,
Population and Development Review, July 2024



Source: Jenny Garcia Arias, “The Demography of Crisis-Driven outflows from Venezuela”, *Population and Development Review*, 2024, <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1111/padr.12651> 40

Perhaps the most careful demographic study to date on the Venezuela crisis comes from Jenny Garcia Arias of INED in France. Working with demographic statistics from seven major receiving countries and from the UN system, she estimated that over 5 million Venezuelans emigrated between 2011 and 2021 alone, and that Venezuela’s 2021 population was about 18 percent smaller than it would have been with normal mortality trends and no net out-migration. Most of the flood of emigrants, by her analysis, took place in the 2015-2020 period—in other words, before the US Southern Border Crisis.

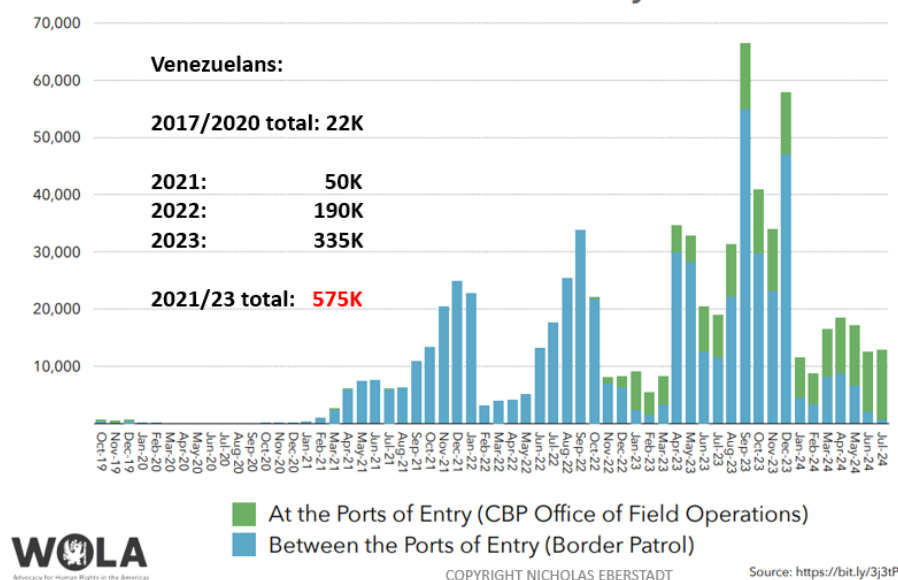
Figure 33
Venezuela’s Migrant Exodus Was Largely Over Before The Biden Influx Began



Source: United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2024). World Population Prospects 2024, Online Edition, <https://population.un.org/wpp/Download/Standard/Population/>.
United States Census Bureau, *International Database*, “Net international migrants, both sexes”, https://www.census.gov/data-tools/demo/idb/#/table?COUNTRY_YEAR=2024&COUNTRY_YR_ANIM=2024&CCODE_SINGLE=VE&CCODE_VE=menu=tableViz&quickReports=CUSTOM&CUSTOM_COLS=NIM&TABLE_RANGE=2010,2024&TABLE_YEARS=2010,2011,2012,2013,2014,2015,2016,2017,2018,2019,2020,2021,2022,2023,2024&TABLE_USE_RANGE=Y&TABLE_USE_YEARS=N&TABLE_STEP=1

Both the UN Population Division and the US Census Bureau offer estimates of net migration for Venezuela for the years 2010-2024. Their assessments are broadly similar, dating the onset of genuinely mass emigration to the year 2016, and the peak of these outflows to the year 2018. US Census Bureau and UNPD estimates track closely from 2010 to 2017 but diverge somewhat after that: no surprise, given our earlier cautionary about the difficulties with migration statistics.

Figure 34 Citizens of Venezuela: CBP Encounters At and Between Ports of Entry



Source: Washington Office on Latin America, "Some Graphics About the Border and Migration", February 27, 2025, https://borderoversight.org/files/wola_migration_charts.pdf

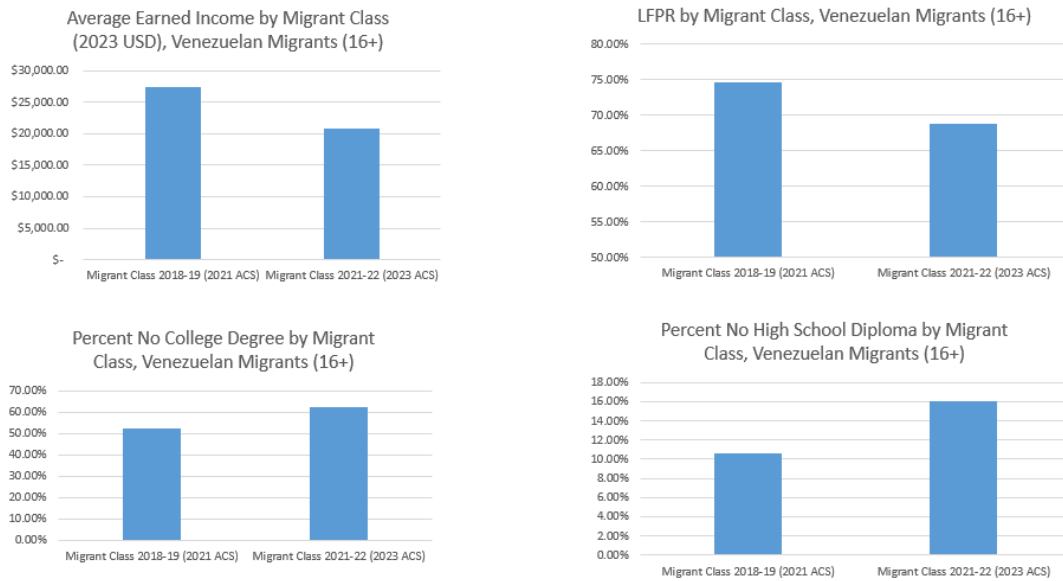
42

This chart from WOLA tracks the surge in US Customs and Border Protection encounters with Venezuelan nationals along the Southern Border between 2021 and 2024. (It cannot measure the number of Venezuelan nationals who entered the US without detection by this route.)

As we see, roughly twenty-five times as many Venezuelans were officially detected in the 2021-23 period as in 2017-20 (the first Trump term). By 2021 most of the Venezuela exodus was over; in fact UNHCR and others were commencing work on resettling émigré Venezuelans back into their native country. But the influx to the USA was only beginning—a testament to the role of opportunity and perceptions of opportunity on the part of would-be migrants.

The Biden-era influx from Venezuela was highly controversial and at the end of the day, decidedly politically unpopular. That said: it is worth bearing in mind that the US ultimately may have taken in roughly a tenth of this Venezuelan exodus. If border security had not been tightened in the 2024 election year, both the US absolute total and its share of the overall diaspora could potentially have been greater.

Figure 35



Source: American Community Survey, 2021/2023, <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/microdata/access.2023.html#list-tab-735824205>

43

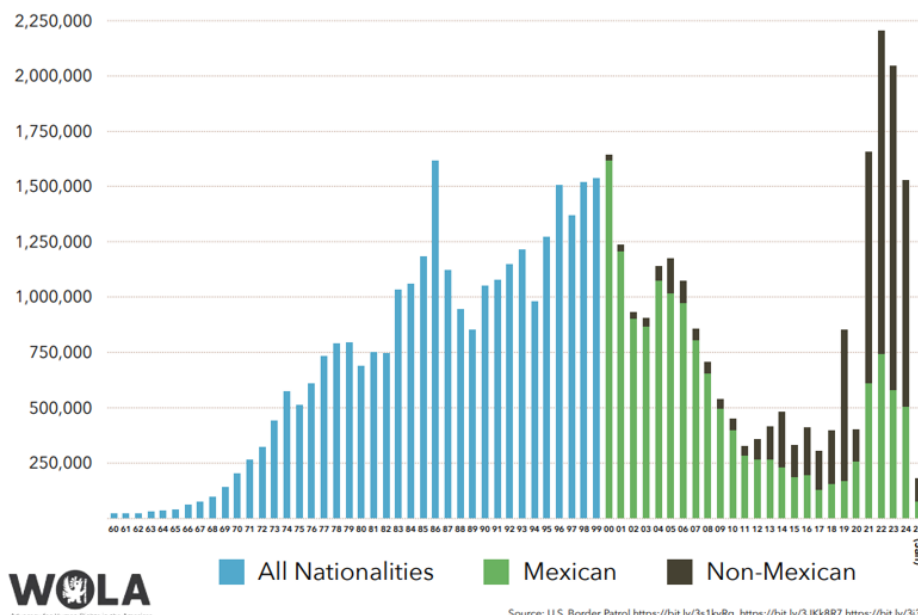
Unsurprisingly, the educational attainment, labor force participation rate, and earned income of Venezuelans who entered the country in the first years of the Southern Border Crisis were lower than those who came to America during the pre-Covid years of the Trump Administration. These charts, drawn from the ACS survey, should be regarded as preliminary, both because ACS may under-report immigration (disproportionately under-reporting illegal immigration?) and because we will have to wait for ACS data on 2023 and 2024 Venezuelan entrants.

7) The Legacy of the Southern Border Crisis, 2021-2024

With the end of the Biden Administration, the Southern Border Crisis appears to be over—at least for now. The incoming Trump II team immediately utilized Executive Orders and other Executive Branch authority to reinforce the Southern Border. Faced with a much less welcoming reception, furthermore, the flow of would-be border crossers plummeted. In fact, according to the US CBP, in March 2025 border apprehensions were lower than at any time since such records have been kept.

Even if low levels of illegal migration are maintained in the future (and they may not be) it is not too soon to take a measure of the Biden years. For the Biden years exposed how very broken America's immigration system has become.

Figure 36
U.S.-Mexico Border Patrol Migrant Encounters



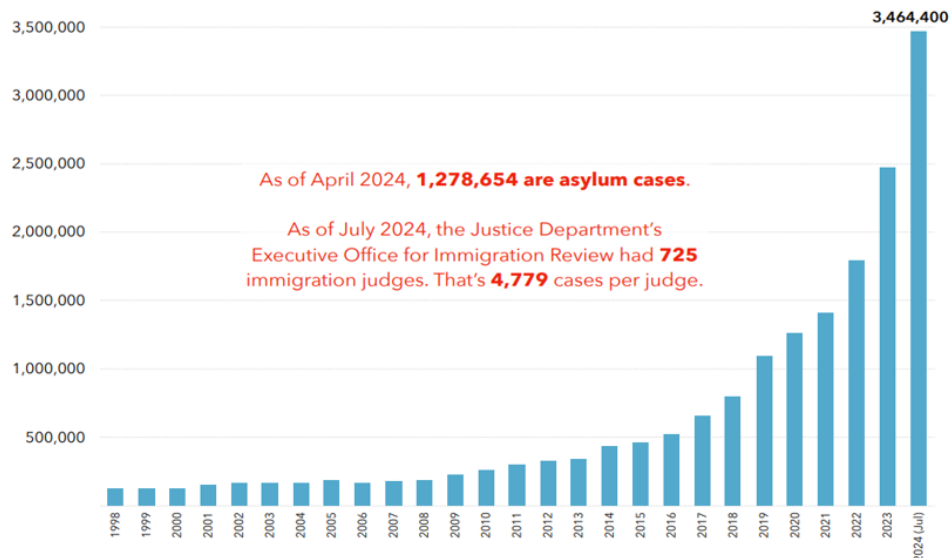
Source: Washington Office on Latin America, "Some Graphics About the Border and Migration", February 27, 2025, https://borderoversight.org/files/wola_migration_charts.pdf

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As this WOLA chart underscores, the Biden era surge was unprecedented—not only in the magnitude of CBP encounters with would be border-crossers, but also in the national composition of those attempting to enter the country illegally. In the years 2021-24, non-Mexicans comprised the overwhelming majority of illegal entrants detected at the Mexican border. The Mexican border, in other words, had become a recognized global gateway for admission to the USA for people circumventing the regular legal immigration and entry process. The internationalization of illegal immigration to the USA through the Southern Border was not new to the Biden term of office: it had been seen once before, in 2019, under Trump I. But the Biden Administration regularized this perverse dynamic: turning it into business as usual for the duration of that term of office. In short: the US border was broken, and the world knew it.

Figure 37

Backlog of Pending Cases in Immigration Courts



WOLA
Washington Office on Latin America

Sources: TRAC Immigration <https://bit.ly/44Is2pM>; Justice Department <https://bit.ly/49yBIER>

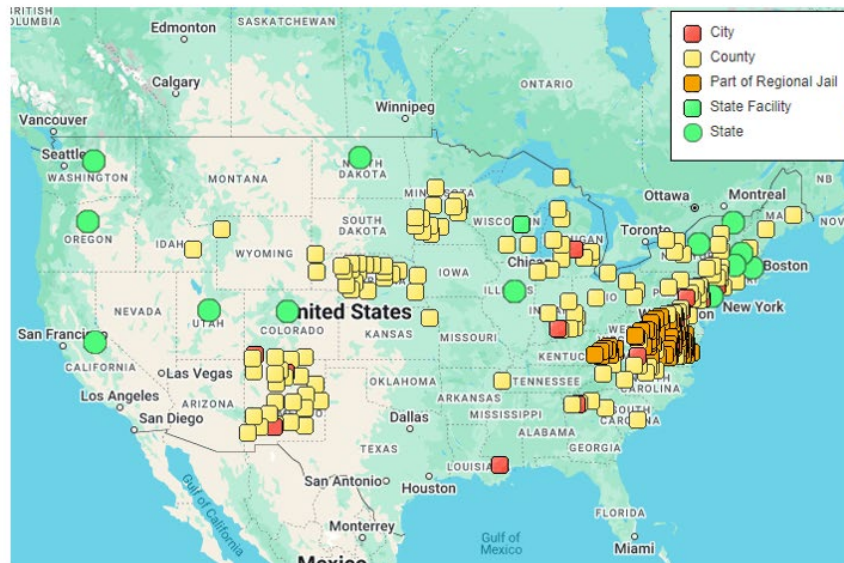
Source: Washington Office on Latin America, "Some Graphics About the Border and Migration", July 16, 2024, https://borderoversight.org/files/wola_migration_charts.pdf

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As this WOLA chart illustrates, the 2021-24 surge of illegal entrants more than doubled the backlog of cases to immigration cases, to nearly three and a half million by mid-year 2024. With over four thousand cases per judge, what American citizen can have confidence that there will be a timely handling of these legal dockets—with due process under the US legal system? More evidence of a broken immigration system.

Figure 38

US Map: Sanctuary Cities, Counties, and States



Source: Jessica M. Vaughan and Bryan Griffith, "Map: Sanctuary Cities, Counties, and States", Center for Immigration Studies, August 27, 2024, <https://cis.org/Map-Sanctuary-Cities-Counties-and-States>

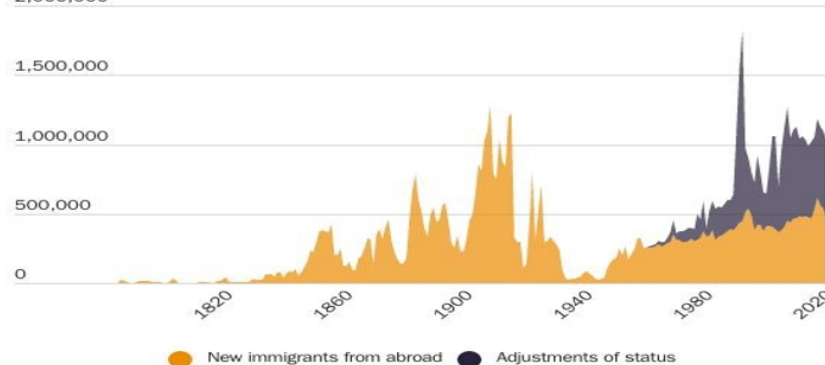
47

As this chart from CIS' Jessica Vaughan and Bryan Griffith details, by 2024 there was an established nationwide splay of cities, counties and states committed to **not** cooperating with the Federal government on enforcing immigration laws. These were so-called "sanctuary" localities. Whatever the ethical merits or arguments of conscience for such resistance to national norms, this map is yet another signal of a dysfunctional national immigration system.

Figure 39

We haven't *always* been a "nation of immigrants":
And if public support today for immigration is poisoned....

Figure 1
Annual immigrant admissions by type, 1783–2019



Sources: U.S. State Department, Immigration and Naturalization Service, Department of Homeland Security, Hans-Jürgen Grabbe, and authors' calculations.

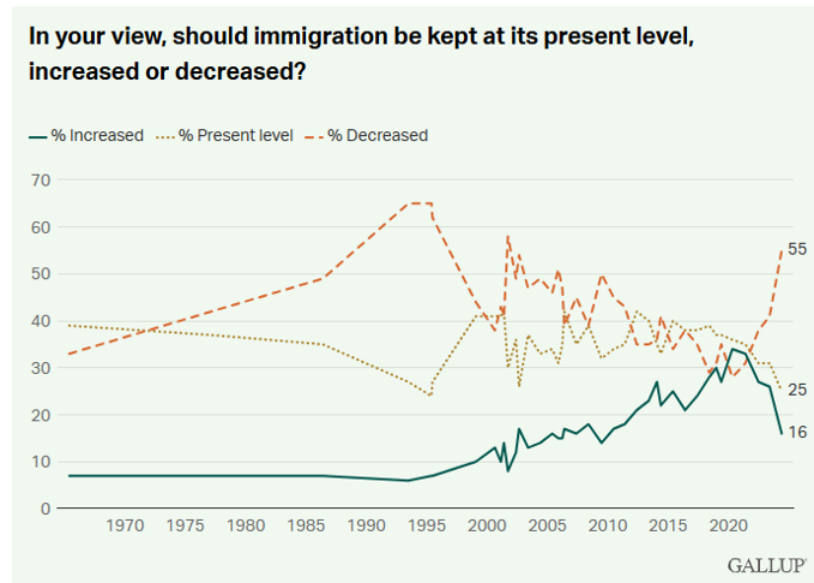
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Source: <https://www.cato.org/policy-analysis/brief-history-us-immigration-policy-colonial-period-present-day#forging-nation-1776-1830>

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As this Cato Institute chart serves to show, and as we have already noted, immigration was severely restricted after World War I—it has happened in America before. Can it happen again?

Figure 40



Source: Gallup, "Immigration", Accessed March 10, 2025, <https://news.gallup.com/poll/1660/immigration.aspx>
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Our broken immigration system risks undermining public confidence in immigration, as this Gallup opinion poll shows. Although public support for increased immigration had been increasing over the 21st Century, and support for reduced immigration had likewise been falling, the Biden era reversed those trends, suddenly and radically.

Will illegal immigration endanger public support for legal immigration? This is the question that policymakers and employers must bear in mind. The US economy needs foreign-born labor and benefits from the talents and skills of its legal migrant population. But recent experience suggests it is not impossible that a broken immigration system could end up endangering legal migration flows as well. America has enacted radical restrictions on all foreign migration before.

Thus far changes in 21st Century immigration policy have mainly been enacted through Executive Orders and other exercises of executive branch authority. But these are manifestly impermanent—immigration policies and practices set from the White House can shift dramatically from one election to the next—as indeed they have. In the hands of the Executive, US immigration rules will inescapably be impermanent, constantly shifting, and unpredictable.

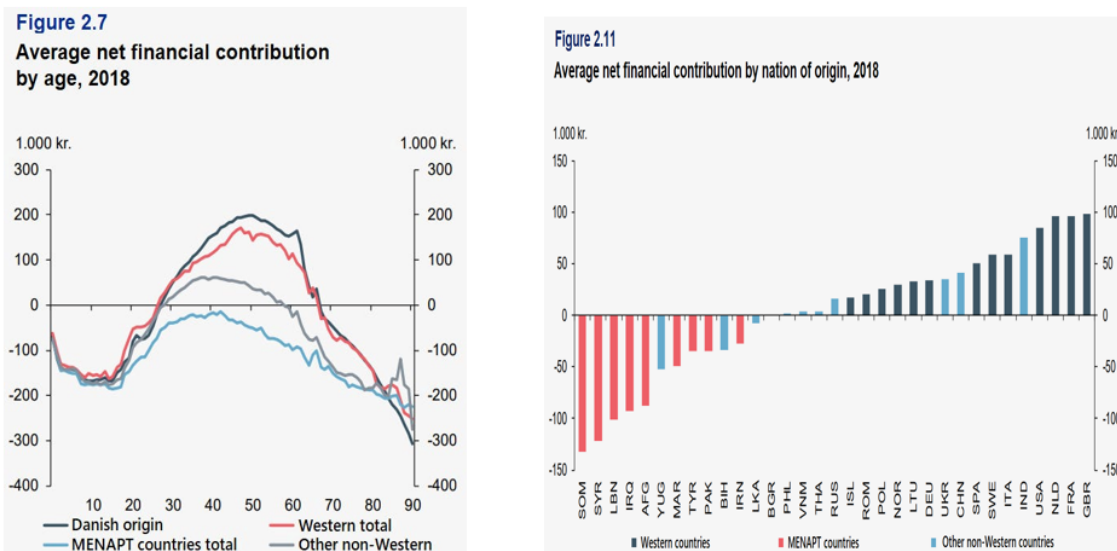
To establish more permanent reforms will require new legislation from Congress. For success, such legislation will likely require compromise among contending factions. Much easier said than done of course—but such compromise among factions was the intent of the Founders who designed our Constitution.

8) Addendum: European Cautionary

Europe is the developed world's other enormous ongoing experiment with mass migration today. Americans may benefit from paying greater attention to it. As of 2024, about 60 million people or roughly 14 percent of the EU-27 population was foreign-born—a proportion comparable the America's. (About 4 percent of the EU population consists of intra-EU migrants, with the rest originating from outside the EU.) A smaller proportion of the EU's foreign-born population is comprised of illegal entrants; though Europe generally tends to accept more asylum seekers than the US, a higher percentage of its foreign-born are regularly processed legal immigrants. The EU experience can help inform Americans as we try to improve and perfect our own approach to immigration. Recent European experience highlights some problems worthy of American consideration, and may also indirectly point to comparative advantages the United States possesses in attracting, assimilating, and unleashing foreign-born talent.

Figure 41 European Cautionary: Who Is Supporting Whom?

Estimated Net Budgetary Contributions by Age and Country of Origin: Denmark 2018



Note: MENAPT: Middle East, North Africa, Pakistan and Turkey

Sources: <https://inquisitivebird.substack.com/p/the-effects-of-immigration-in-denmark>,

citing Danish Finance Ministry: <https://fm.dk/udgivelser/2021/oktober/oekonomisk-analyse-indvanderes-nettobidrag-til-de-offentlige-finanser-i-2018/>

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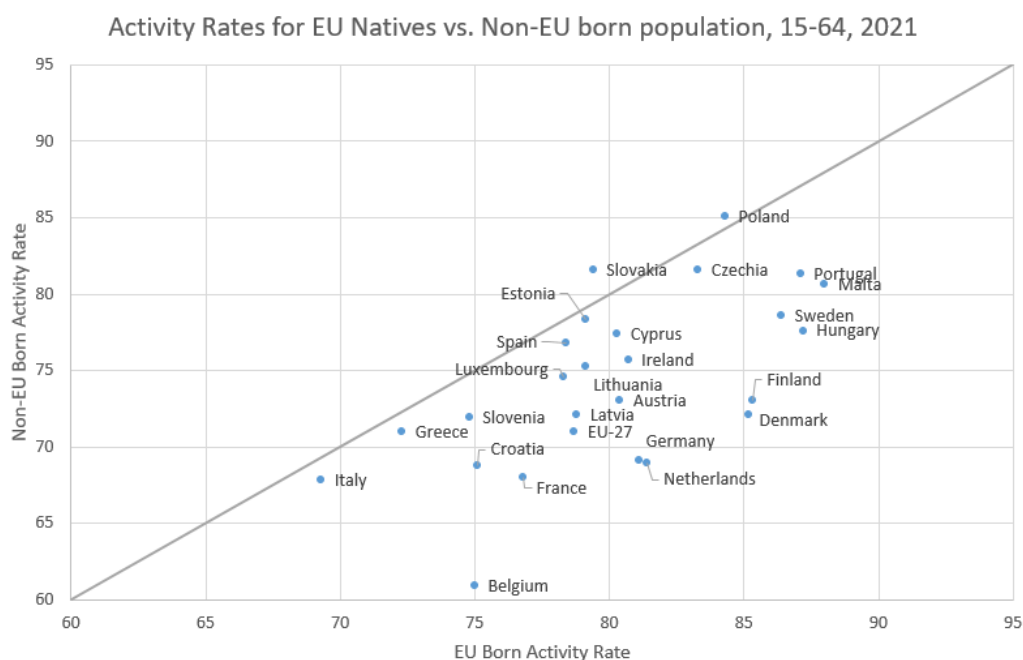
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One of the few detailed studies of the fiscal impact of immigrant groups by age and country of origin is offered by Denmark's Ministry of Finance. The calculations in this study underscore the tremendous variations in net budgetary contributions offered, or burdens imposed, over the life cycle according to place of birth. Native-born Danes were estimated to be net contributors to the Danish fisc from their mid-20s to their late 60s, as were immigrants from other Western countries. But immigrants from "MENAPT"—the Middle East, North Africa, Pakistan and Turkey—were estimated to be, on average, net claimants on the Danish budget throughout the entire course of their life cycle. While immigrants from Britain were estimated on average to be net contributors of almost 100,000 DKK (about \$15,000) a year to the Danish budget,

immigrants from Somalia were estimated to be on average net claimants of over 130,000 DKK (about \$20,000) a year.

Denmark's welfare state is much more generous than America's and its taxation rates are likewise higher, so we would not expect to see parallel results if such calculations were available for the USA. But the exercise does emphasize how important educational attainment/skills, labor force participation, and social assimilation are to the fiscal impact of immigrant groups—and how dramatically these can differ by country of origin. US immigration policy would be better informed with more research like that undertaken by the Danish Ministry of Finance.

Figure 42
European Cautionary: Who Is Supporting Whom, Again?



Source: http://appsso.eurostat.ec.europa.eu/nui/show.do?dataset=lfsa_argacob&lang=en, EU LFPR series: "EU27 countries (from 2020) except reporting country," Non-EU series: "Non-EU27 countries (from 2020) nor reporting country," Accessed June 16, 2022.

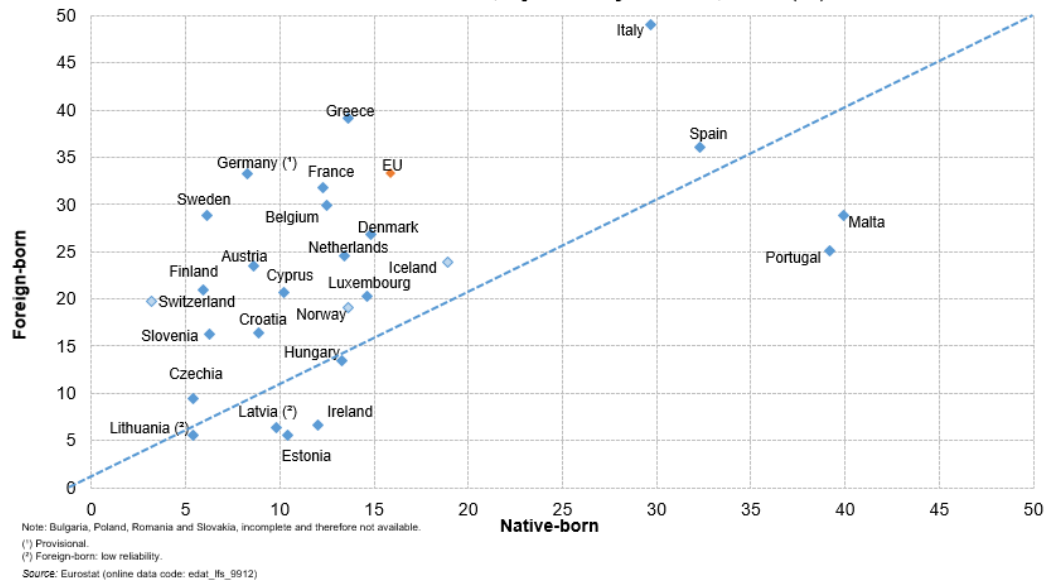
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A key rationale for Europe's pivot to a mass migration policy was the imperative of compensating for shrinkage of the native-born labor force (a consequence of prolonged sub-replacement fertility rates). But in practice labor force participation rates are generally lower in Europe for immigrants from outside the EU—in some cases substantially lower. In Belgium, the LFPR gap between EU native and those born outside the EU is almost 15 percentage points for the overall 15-64 working age group. The discrepancy reflects among other things the much lower workforce participation presence of non-EU female migrants. Only in Slovakia and Poland—two of the EU countries with the strictest immigration rules—were LFPRs for the non-EU population ever so slightly higher than for the EU-born.

In the US the labor force participation rate for men and women together tends to be higher for immigrants than native-born Americans. But as the European example demonstrates, there is no reason to assume this is a 'natural' state of affairs.

Figure 43
European Cautionary: Not A Skilled Labor Magnet
 Share of the population aged 25-54 years with at most a lower secondary level of educational attainment, by country of birth, 2020 (%)



Source: https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/statistics-explained/index.php/Migrant_integration_statistics_-_education#Educational_attainment Accessed June 16, 2022.

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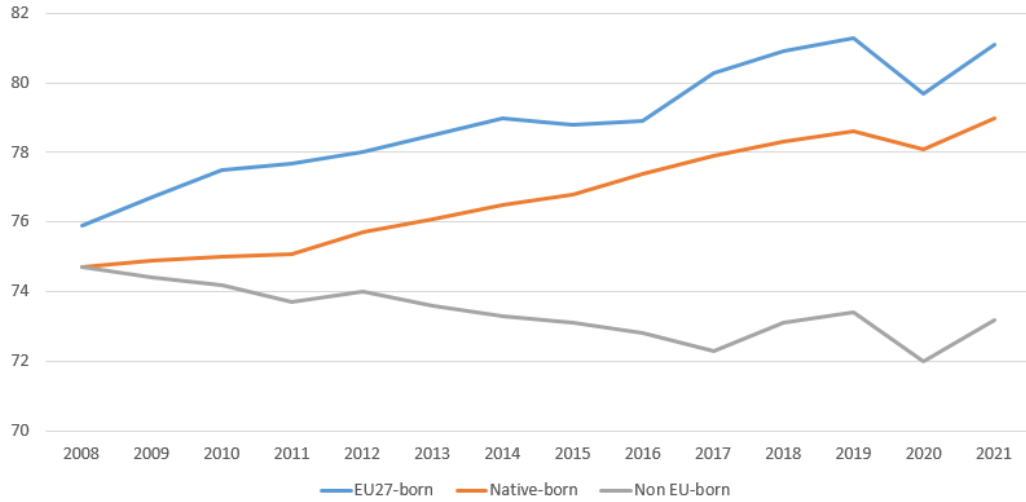
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One of the assumptions behind the EU's turn to mass immigration was that foreign labor, through its contributions to the national economy and the tax base, would help bolster public finances and (at the very least) postpone the crisis of the European welfare state. But things may not have worked as planned. Generally speaking, EU countries have "imported" foreign-born populations with markedly lower educational attainment profiles than their own native-born populations. In Germany, just 8 percent of the country's native-born prime working age (25-54) population has incomplete secondary education—as against 33 percent of their foreign-born counterparts.

In the context of the EU's welfare states, differences in labor force participation and educational attainment may establish non-EU born immigrants as disproportionate claimants upon the fisc. (Apart from the Danish study above, however, we have not seen research to test that hypothesis.) In addition to social benefits for the pre-retirement cohorts, there is the question of pension benefits for older age groups. Given the progressivity of most European national pension programs, groups with lower educational attainment and shorter lifetime work histories may prove to be heavier net claimants on public finances.

Figure 44
European Cautionary: What Is Wrong With This Picture?

Development of Activity Rates for the population aged 20-64, EU-27
2008-2021



Source: https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/LFSA_ARGACOB_custom_2930056/default/table?lang=en, Accessed June 16, 2022.

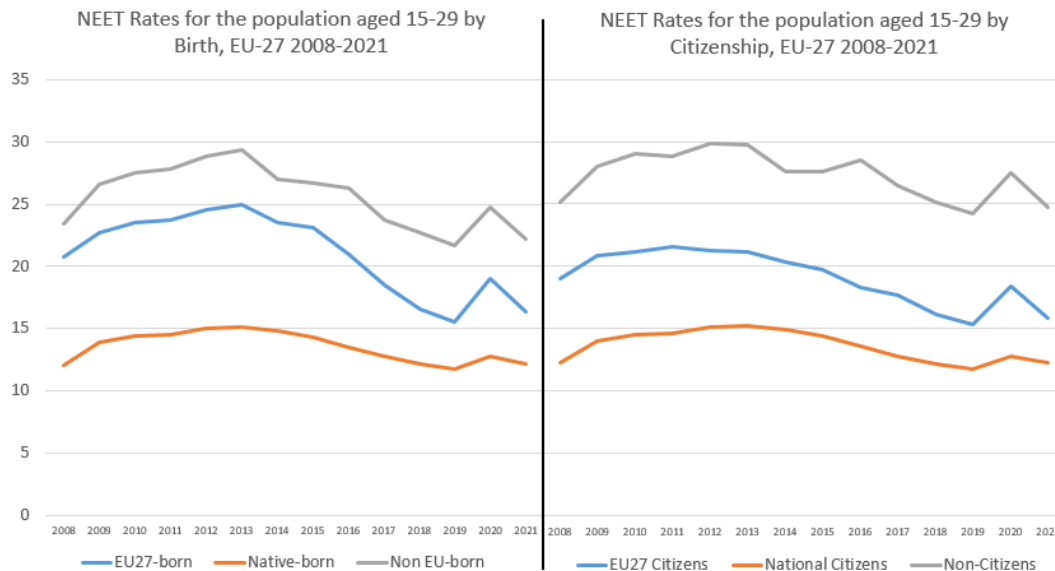
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While labor force participation rates for the EU-born have been rising since the Great Recession, those for immigrants from outside the EU have been falling. The gap is widest between intra-EU migrants and those born in countries outside the EU.

Americans have not had to worry about this sort of problem at home—so far.

Figure 45
European Cautionary: Look Who Isn't Assimilating



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Sources: https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/EDAT_LFSE_28_custom_2930175/default/table?lang=en and https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/EDAT_LFSE_23_custom_2930185/default/table?lang=en, Accessed June 16, 2022.

NEET is an acronym for “neither employed nor in education or training”—a group largely consisting of “dropouts”. (Mothers at home with children could also in theory be found in this grouping, although it is not clear how much of the “NEET gap” this group accounts for, if any.)

According to Eurostat, the statistical service for the EU, European NEET rates for young people are consistently and significantly higher for those born outside the EU. The “NEET gap” is suggestive of an appreciable and enduring assimilation problem for Europe with respect to many of its young foreign-born immigrants—especially those originating from North Africa and the greater Middle East. To state the obvious: the assimilation problem highlighted in this chart appears to be particularly acute for migrants from some Muslim-majority sending countries.

To date, America has not been troubled by the sorts of assimilation problems Europe seems to be experiencing (even if most immigrants to Europe appear to be assimilating tolerably well). Americans tend to take assimilation of newcomers to our shores for granted, and the historical record would seem to bear out such confidence. But Americans and Europeans alike might benefit from a better understanding of how and why assimilation seems to work more smoothly for certain pairings of sending and receiving countries. At this writing the subject of assimilation—who succeeds, who fails, and why—is extraordinarily sensitive in Europe. Inquiry into this question has suffered from a pervasive “chilling effect”. This is unfortunate, as enforced silence is more unlikely to help address the problem.